

THE RIGHT NOT TO BE SAVED

KNOWLEDGE, POWER, AND THE DANGERS
OF FORCED GOOD

MYSTERY
DISCIPLINE
INITIATION
WISDOM
RESPONSIBILITY

PATERNALISM
ENGINEERING
CONVERSION
CONTROL
UNIFORMITY



A CONTRARIAN INQUIRY INTO FREEDOM,
CONSCIENCE, AND CIVILIZATIONAL MATURITY

Copyright © [2026] Axiologic Research

All rights reserved.

KDP publishing rights held by Outfinity SRL (Iași, Romania).

Available for free at www.axiologic.net.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

This work was created under the umbrella of Axiologic Research as part of two interconnected research programs, one dedicated to Artificial Intelligence and the other to Outfinitism, both led by Sînică Alboaie. To explore the details of how these two programs intersect and build upon each other, we invite readers to visit the Outfinity Venture Studio page at www.outfinity.ch.

While Artificial Intelligence language models were used to assist with text generation, the foundational philosophy, thematic structure, and analytical approach derive exclusively from the author's decades of dedicated study of social phenomena, social technologies, and genuine hard technologies resulting from various European and self funded research projects. Recently, within the Achilles research project, we have been deeply studying AI generated literature and its automated verification using neuro symbolic approaches; all the free books made available to the public are part of the suite of works we use to test our latest technologies.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

INTRODUCTION Good Is A Form Of Power

CHAPTER 1 The Wisdom Of The Closed Door

CHAPTER 2 Not Every Mind Receives The Same Idea

CHAPTER 3 The Price Of Understanding

CHAPTER 4 Humanism'S Double Ledger

CHAPTER 5 The Violence Of Premature Modernization

CHAPTER 6 Good With A Police Escort

CHAPTER 7 The Body Is The Last Border

CHAPTER 8 Leave Some People Alone

CHAPTER 9 Leave Some Cultures Alone

CHAPTER 10 Selective Help

CHAPTER 11 The Perfect Missionary

CHAPTER 12 Cognitive Sovereignty

CHAPTER 13 When Force Is Right

CHAPTER 14 The Savior'S Burden

EPILOGUE Refusal Is Not A Bug

INTRODUCTION – GOOD IS A FORM OF POWER

The ability to benefit another person does not create jurisdiction over that person.

The Hidden Jurisdiction

Modern political language has a blind spot. It knows how to talk about power when power is greedy, violent, corrupt, racist, fanatical, or nakedly self-interested. It becomes strangely inarticulate when power arrives carrying a vaccine, a curriculum, a welfare payment, a development grant, a safety standard, a mental-health intervention, a recommendation engine, or a promise to make us healthier, richer, calmer, safer, more educated, more rational, or more inclusive. Then power disappears from the description. There is only help.

That disappearance is the subject of this book.

The moral trick is simple. First define an outcome as good. Then show that an institution can increase the probability of that outcome. Then quietly infer a right to intervene. The final step rarely receives the scrutiny given to the first two. We argue endlessly about whether a policy works and much less about the prior question: even if it works, who acquired the authority to impose it?

This is not an argument that modernity failed. It is harder than that. Modernity succeeded spectacularly at many things. Sanitation, antibiotics, vaccination, literacy, mass schooling, safer childbirth, social insurance, public infrastructure, and scientific medicine reduced suffering on a scale that romantic critics of modern institutions sometimes evade. The fall in child mortality and the rise in life expectancy are not public-relations tricks. Compulsory schooling has produced measurable gains in education and, in some settings, later-life outcomes. Vaccination has eliminated or suppressed diseases that once killed and disabled millions. A serious critique begins by admitting the scoreboard.

The problem is what success teaches the successful. Institutions that save lives are tempted to conclude that they understand life. Institutions that teach reading are tempted to decide what a person should read, what history he should remember, what language his children should speak, and what kind of citizen he should become. A welfare system that prevents starvation discovers that it can condition food and shelter on administratively approved behavior. A health

authority that controls an epidemic discovers that it can define responsible citizenship. An educational bureaucracy that increases literacy discovers a mandate to manufacture values. A technology company that reduces friction discovers that it can reduce hesitation, deviance, and refusal as well.

The central claim of this book is deliberately impolite: the right to do good to someone is not contained inside the fact that you know how to help him. Competent adults retain a right to refuse benefits, treatments, identities, curricula, optimization, and forms of civilization that other people sincerely believe would improve them. They retain that right even when their refusal is foolish. Freedom that protects only correct decisions is a reward system, not freedom.

The same problem exists at the level of communities. Modern humanitarianism often assumes that cultural difference is a temporary defect on the road to a shared institutional endpoint. The vocabulary changes across centuries - salvation, civilization, development, modernization, inclusion, capacity building, resilience, evidence-based policy - but the structure can remain recognizable. One society possesses a model of the good life. Another is described by what it lacks. Money, schooling, law, medicine, governance, media, or technology then becomes the vehicle by which the second is made legible to the first.

Sometimes this is liberation. Sometimes it is conversion with a secular logo.

The distinction is difficult because the converted may genuinely benefit. A colonial school can teach literacy and destroy a language. A welfare program can prevent destitution and create a surveillance architecture around the poor. A public-health intervention can reduce infection and normalize emergency powers. A development project can build roads and make a previously autonomous community dependent on prices, credentials, permits, and institutions controlled elsewhere. Benefits and domination can coexist. The presence of one does not cancel the other.

The diagram below makes the escalation explicit. It is not a moral ranking in which the first box is always legitimate and the last always illegitimate. Its purpose is to show that the recipient's practical ability to refuse decreases as the intervention moves right, and the intervener therefore acquires a heavier burden of justification.

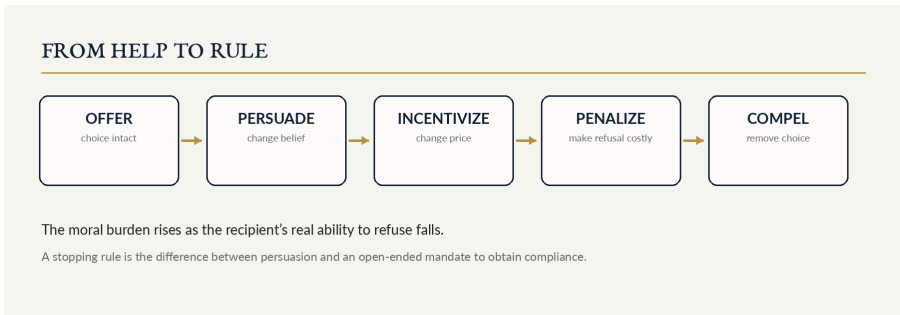


Figure 1 – From Help to Rule: the declining space for refusal

The useful question at every step is what changes when the recipient says no. If nothing changes, we are near advice. If refusal changes prices, access, legal status, or bodily control, the institution is already exercising a stronger form of power and should describe it accurately.

Power is easiest to recognize when the person exercising it wants something for himself. The tax collector wants revenue, the censor wants silence, the conqueror wants territory. Benevolent power is harder to see because its stated object is the welfare of the person being acted upon. A school official wants the child educated. A physician wants the patient protected. A welfare agency wants a household stable. A content platform wants the user less exposed to fraud or extremism. The aim may be sincere and the effect may be beneficial, yet the structure is still one in which one actor claims authority to alter another actor's options. The language of care can hide that jurisdictional fact.

Three questions therefore have to be kept separate. First, is the proposed good actually good? Second, does the intervention reliably produce it? Third, even if the answer to both is yes, what gives the intervener the right to override refusal? Political debate often collapses the third question into the first two. Once a policy has passed an effectiveness test, resistance is redescribed as ignorance, irrationality, selfishness, misinformation, pathology, or lack of capacity. Sometimes those descriptions are accurate. They still do not, by themselves, answer the question of authority.

The distinction becomes clearer if we follow a simple escalation. Advice leaves the recipient's option set intact. Persuasion tries to change preferences while preserving formal choice. Incentives change the price of refusal. Penalties make refusal costly. Compulsion removes the choice or punishes it so severely that the difference becomes largely semantic. These are not morally identical acts. A society

that refuses to name the transition from one to the next makes it easier for benevolence to become rule without ever admitting that rule has begun.

The argument of this book is not that the first step is pure and the last step is always evil. It is that each step changes the burden of justification. The stronger the intervention, the less adequate it is to say that the intended outcome is desirable. A civilization worthy of calling itself free must know not only how to improve people but when improvement ceases to be its business.

A Book Against the Reflex to Rescue

Modern liberal societies are particularly skilled at hiding this ambiguity because they condemn old forms of hierarchy while practicing sophisticated new forms of gating. They tell the public that knowledge should be open while protecting military research, clinical practice, source code, private networks, investment information, security clearances, elite credentials, and decision rights. They celebrate universal access while constructing institutions in which the most consequential forms of access remain selective. The real dispute is not whether societies should have gates. Every serious society has them. The dispute is which gates are legitimate, who controls them, and whether the person outside the gate can ever become qualified to cross it.

Ancient mystery traditions understood something that modern universalism often pretends not to know: information is not identical to understanding. An idea can be true and useless, true and destabilizing, true and dangerous, true and comic in the wrong setting, or true and almost impossible to perceive without years of preparation. The Eleusinian mysteries, Pythagorean disciplines, priestly schools, craft guilds, monastic orders, and initiatory traditions differed enormously, and many protected privilege or superstition. Yet their shared intuition deserves recovery. Sequence matters. Context matters. Attention matters. Readiness matters. Some knowledge changes the person who receives it, and some knowledge can only be used responsibly after the recipient has acquired capacities that the knowledge itself does not provide.

Psychology gives us a non-mystical way to state the point. Experts and novices do not merely know different quantities of the same facts; they often organize problems differently. Prior knowledge changes the effect of instruction. Working-memory constraints make explanations that help beginners obstruct experts and explanations that delight experts overwhelm beginners. Motivated reasoning changes what evidence can enter a belief system. Psychological reactance

can make attempted persuasion strengthen resistance. The curse of knowledge makes it difficult for people who know something to reconstruct what it is like not to know it. A sentence does not enter a neutral mind. It enters an architecture.

This does not prove a ladder of human worth. It does prove that equal dignity is compatible with unequal readiness, unequal competence, unequal attention, and unequal ability to integrate a particular body of knowledge at a particular moment. That distinction is routinely accepted in aviation, surgery, cryptography, nuclear operations, and scientific laboratories. It becomes morally embarrassing only when applied to culture and cognition, where modern rhetoric prefers to pretend that access to words equals access to meaning.

The language of "levels of consciousness" is therefore neither obviously profound nor obviously meaningless. Stage theories of adult development and ego development have empirical support and serious methodological limitations. Metacognitive calibration, perspective-taking, temporal horizon, tolerance of ambiguity, and the ability to revise one's self-model vary among individuals and across contexts. But there is no credible single meter that ranks entire persons, much less whole ethnic or national populations, from lower to higher humanity. The biological hypothesis should not be protected from inquiry merely because it is politically dangerous; nor should it be promoted beyond the evidence merely because it is politically transgressive. Population structure and gene-culture coevolution are real. A biological hierarchy of "fitness for modernity" is not established by those facts and is not required for the argument of this book.

The stronger argument needs no racial metaphysics. Human beings differ enough as individuals, institutions differ enough in competence, cultures differ enough in accumulated norms, and social systems differ enough in their capacity to metabolize change that one-size-fits-all salvation is already epistemically reckless.

The thesis, then, is not that nobody should ever be compelled. Children are not simply small autonomous adults. Acute incapacity exists. Violence exists. Contagion creates externalities. Catastrophic technologies can impose risks on people who never consented. A society that refuses all coercion would not remain a society for long. The thesis is that coercion must stop laundering itself through the vocabulary of care. If force is necessary, call it force. If another person's refusal imposes a concrete risk on others, name the risk. If a community violates the bodily integrity of people trapped inside it, name the victims. But do not convert every disagreement with the institutional good into a diagnosis of backwardness.

The right not to be saved begins where modern benevolence becomes most uncomfortable: with the possibility that the other person has heard the argument, understood enough of it, and still does not want the future you have designed for him.

If every "no" is evidence that the speaker needs more education, therapy, nudging, monitoring, or correction, benevolence has no stopping rule.

The difficult cases begin precisely where a simplistic anti-state or anti-modern argument would prefer to stop. Vaccination really did suppress devastating diseases. Compulsory schooling really did increase educational attainment in many settings. Social insurance really did prevent forms of destitution that private charity could not reliably handle. Public sanitation, food standards, workplace rules, child protection, and emergency medicine are not merely ideological disguises. The modern project earned much of its authority by producing outcomes that previous societies could not produce at scale.

That success created a moral habit. When institutions repeatedly prevent suffering, the difference between capacity and jurisdiction begins to feel pedantic. It is tempting to conclude that the only serious question is whether intervention works. Yet history is full of programs that combined measurable benefit with domination: colonial schools that taught literacy while erasing languages; development schemes that built infrastructure while destroying local institutions; welfare systems that kept people alive while making survival conditional on bureaucratic obedience; psychiatric systems that rescued some people in crisis while institutionalizing others for being inconvenient; public-health systems that protected populations while normalizing exceptional powers. The ledger has two columns because reality does.

A coherent inquiry therefore has to resist two comforting myths at once. The first myth says that modern benevolence is simply emancipation and that those who resist it are residues of ignorance. The second says that modern institutions are merely instruments of control and that older, local, or traditional orders were somehow innocent. Neither survives evidence. Families, tribes, churches, villages, markets, professions, and states can all dominate. The question is not whether power can be abolished. It cannot. The question is how far a claim to help should travel before it meets a boundary.

The chapters that follow move from the oldest form of that boundary, the closed door around knowledge, to the newest, the cognitive boundary threatened by systems able to model and persuade an individual continuously. The route

matters. Ancient initiation shows why context and readiness can matter. Cognitive science shows that understanding is not uniformly distributed. Modern history shows how the desire to improve becomes a technology of standardization. Public health shows the strongest case for overriding refusal. Artificial intelligence shows what happens when persuasion becomes personalized, cheap, tireless, and measurable. The same question appears in each domain: when does helping become governing?

PART I HIDDEN KNOWLEDGE AND HUMAN DIFFERENCE

CHAPTER 1 — THE WISDOM OF THE CLOSED DOOR

Secrecy is not automatically wisdom, but disclosure is not automatically virtue.

Initiation Before Information

The modern mind has a reflexive suspicion of closed doors. We associate secrecy with conspiracy, initiation with manipulation, hierarchy with injustice, and restricted knowledge with elites protecting themselves. Often the suspicion is deserved. Priests have hidden ignorance behind sacred language. Guilds have used secrecy to keep competitors out. States classify embarrassment alongside genuine security risks. Professions construct jargon that sometimes protects expertise and sometimes protects rent.

But the opposite superstition is newer and not obviously wiser: that information becomes morally better when universally and immediately available.

Ancient mystery cults provide a useful counter-image. The Eleusinian mysteries did not publish a handbook explaining everything that occurred in initiation. Pythagorean traditions associated learning with discipline, silence, sequence, and membership. Religious and philosophical schools often separated exoteric teaching from esoteric practice. We should not romanticize them. There is no need to imagine that the ancients possessed a lost scientific supertheory. Their institutions were human institutions, with status, theatre, monopoly, and credulity mixed with insight. The important point is structural. They did not assume that the same content should be delivered in the same way to every person at the same time.

That can be rational for at least four reasons.

First, meaning is sequential. Many ideas require concepts that must already exist in the listener. A proof is not concealed from a child by malice when the teacher postpones it until arithmetic, algebra, and notation are in place. The information could be displayed earlier, but disclosure would not produce possession. At best it would produce memorized symbols.

Second, meaning can depend on practice. A martial technique, contemplative exercise, surgical procedure, or scientific method is not fully represented by its

verbal description. The recipient needs habits of attention, error detection, and restraint. Ancient initiation often coupled knowledge to ritual because ritual imposed context and cost. The ritual could be superstitious; the institutional intuition was still sound. Some forms of understanding are enacted before they are articulated.

Third, knowledge can create risk. This is obvious in modern dual-use science. Detailed biological methods, exploit chains in cybersecurity, methods for scalable manipulation, and capabilities for autonomous systems can have very different social consequences depending on who possesses them and why. Bostrom's concept of information hazards states the problem cleanly: information can cause harm because it is true, useful, and transmissible. Resnik's work on openness and secrecy in science makes the same conflict less dramatic but no less real. Science requires openness to correct itself, yet some information is dangerous precisely because science succeeded.

The ancient mystery traditions are useful not because they offer a lost political model to imitate, but because they began from an assumption modern information culture finds uncomfortable: a truth can change meaning when detached from preparation. At Eleusis, Samothrace, and other initiatory centers, the boundary between outsider and initiate was not simply a boundary between the ignorant and the informed. It was a sequence. Participation involved travel, waiting, purification, ritual action, restricted speech, and a culminating experience whose content was not casually broadcast. Scholars such as Walter Burkert, Hugh Bowden, Jan Bremmer, Michael Cosmopoulos, and Yulia Ustinova disagree over many details, but the existence of structured initiation and secrecy is not controversial.

It would be romantic nonsense to infer that the ancients possessed superior science hidden from the crowd. Much of what was guarded may have been symbolic, theatrical, theological, or socially functional rather than factually profound. That is precisely why the structure is more interesting than the content. The initiatory system treated understanding as an event that occurred in a prepared person, not as a packet that could be copied into any mind. Modern education still knows this in practice. A proof in topology, a surgical technique, a legal doctrine, or a dangerous laboratory protocol cannot be made useful merely by publishing the final sentences. Background knowledge, conceptual vocabulary, tacit skill, and disciplined attention alter what the receiver can do with the same words.

Secrecy also created commitment. The initiate had paid a cost before receiving the privileged content. That cost could screen for seriousness, coordinate a group, intensify memory, and make the experience socially consequential. The cost could

also manipulate. Ritual exhaustion, status pressure, fear of exclusion, and the prestige of insiders can make bad ideas feel deep. The same mechanism that produces commitment can produce cultic capture. The lesson is therefore not "the ancients were right to hide truth." It is narrower and more durable: unrestricted disclosure and meaningful understanding are different things, and institutions have always experimented with ways of connecting access to preparation.

This also explains why the experience of initiation can be meaningful even when the secret, written as a sentence, looks disappointing. The sequence has changed the receiver before the final content arrives. Modern readers often treat that as proof of manipulation; sometimes it is. But education itself works by changing the receiver. A theorem understood after years of mathematics is not the same cognitive event as the same symbols shown to a beginner. The ethical question is therefore whether preparation enlarges competence or merely manufactures deference. That distinction will follow us from temples to universities, states, and AI systems.

When the Closed Door Is Rational

Fourth, restriction can create a price of attention. A secret is not necessarily valuable because it is hidden, but a gate can require effort before access. Ritual, apprenticeship, examinations, probation, practice, and contribution all make the recipient reveal something that a click cannot reveal: persistence. Sosis and Bressler's work on costly signaling in religious communes illustrates a broader principle. Cost can screen commitment. Extreme ritual is not a model for modern education, but the mechanism is important. People treat differently what they had to become capable of receiving.

Modern society did not abolish these mechanisms. It secularized them and became embarrassed by the comparison. Medical knowledge is open in journals, but the right to cut into a body is licensed. Cryptographic papers are public, but access to production keys is restricted. Nuclear physics is taught, but nuclear command authority is gated. Universities praise universal knowledge while rationing mentorship, laboratories, recommendation letters, networks, and prestige. Corporations celebrate information sharing while protecting source code, customer data, strategy, and deal flow. Democracies celebrate transparency while operating security clearances.

The result is not a world without mysteries. It is a world in which some mysteries are called credentials, some are called compliance, some are called national security, and some are simply too expensive to enter.

The useful question is therefore not whether gates are morally pure. They are not. The useful question is what a gate is selecting for. A gate based on family name, race, inherited caste, or permanent status is not made defensible by the fact that some knowledge is dangerous. A gate based on demonstrated competence, demonstrated restraint, or exposure to consequences can be. The distinction is not cosmetic. One freezes social hierarchy; the other tries, imperfectly, to bind access to the capacities that make access safer or more meaningful.

Open-access ideology often ignores another problem: universal publication can destroy the ecology that made the knowledge intelligible. An initiatory tradition stripped of sequence becomes content. A local practice stripped of context becomes a lifestyle product. A scientific result stripped of method becomes a headline. A philosophical insight stripped of the years of confusion that made it necessary becomes a quotation. Information spreads faster than formation.

The internet accelerated that asymmetry. AI will accelerate it again. Soon a person may be able to request an explanation of almost any subject at any level, translated into any language, personalized to any cognitive profile, generated instantly. The old scarcity of words will disappear. The scarcity that remains will be harder: judgment, attention, integration, and the ability to act without creating damage.

The ancient closed door was often unjust. But the intuition behind it was not primitive. A civilization that possesses biotechnology, autonomous agents, industrial-scale persuasion, and increasingly powerful models should be less naive about unrestricted disclosure than a village mystery cult, not more.

We did not outgrow initiation. We built technologies powerful enough to make bad initiation dangerous.

The distinctions in Table 1 keep the argument from collapsing all forms of restriction into one category. A gate can protect a real externality, or it can merely protect the people who already stand behind it. The difference is the relationship between the criterion and the capability being governed.

Table 1 – Gates that track capability, and gates that drift into caste

Gate	What it protects	Legitimate signal	Typical failure
Prerequisite knowledge	Comprehension and safe use	Demonstrated foundation	Credential inflation
Professional license	Third-party safety	Observed competence	Cartel protection
Security clearance	High-impact assets	Role-relevant trust and need	Political loyalty tests
Laboratory access	Biosecurity and containment	Training and procedure	Closed insider culture
Hereditary status	Inherited hierarchy	Birth or identity	Caste by design

The final row is not a historical footnote; it is the diagnostic contrast. A defensible gate gives an outsider a meaningful route to become qualified. A caste makes the person's origin the qualification itself.

Modernity did not abolish gates; it changed their names. A pilot may read aeronautical manuals freely but cannot legally command an airliner without demonstrated competence. A medical student can study pharmacology, yet controlled substances and clinical procedures remain regulated. A cryptographer can read about vulnerabilities while access to production keys is restricted. A biologist can study gene editing while laboratories impose training, biosafety levels, material controls, and review. These arrangements are not remnants of priestcraft. They recognize that knowledge becomes socially different when it crosses from description into capability.

The useful distinction is between a gate that protects inherited status and a gate that tracks a relevant competence or risk. Birth caste is a bad gate because the criterion is disconnected from the capability being governed and is effectively impossible to cross. A surgical credential can be a defensible gate because the criterion is linked to patient risk and can, at least in principle, be earned. The same institution can move from one category toward the other. Professions can turn competence requirements into cartel protection. Security agencies can classify embarrassment as danger. Universities can use jargon as an initiation language whose main function is status. The existence of abuse does not make every gate irrational; it makes the design and contestability of the gate part of the moral problem.

This matters more as the cost of converting knowledge into action falls. A chemistry text once required a laboratory, equipment, materials, training, and time before it could become a dangerous capability. An AI system can increasingly bridge several of those gaps by turning vague intent into code, procedures, designs, or experimental plans. The moral object that may need gating is no longer the proposition itself but the assistance that operationalizes it. A society can keep scientific claims open while restricting access to particular materials, execution environments, autonomous agents, or high-risk procedures.

The ancient closed door should not be reconstructed as an aristocratic ideal. It should remind us that access has always had an architecture. The serious modern question is whether that architecture is explicit, relevant to the risk, crossable through demonstrated capacity, and narrow enough not to become a permanent class system. In a world of increasingly executable knowledge, pretending that every gate is censorship is as naive as pretending that every gate is wisdom.

CHAPTER 2 — NOT EVERY MIND RECEIVES THE SAME IDEA

Equality of persons does not imply interchangeability of minds.

Novices, Experts, and Cognitive Distance

One of modern culture's strangest politenesses is the insistence that differences in understanding should be discussed as temporary accidents rather than structural facts. We accept that people differ in height, memory, temperament, mathematical ability, language, impulse control, domain expertise, patience, social perception, and risk tolerance. Then, when the subject becomes worldview or political judgment, we often speak as if every mind were the same instrument with a different set of files loaded into it. It is not.

The classic work of Chi, Feltovich, and Glaser showed that experts and novices categorize physics problems differently. Novices attend to surface features. Experts are more likely to organize problems around underlying principles. This is not merely a difference in the number of facts remembered. The same problem is represented differently because prior knowledge has changed the cognitive structure through which the problem is seen.

Cognitive-load research makes the consequence practical. Sweller and colleagues have spent decades showing that instruction interacts with the architecture of working memory and long-term knowledge. Kalyuga and collaborators described the expertise-reversal effect: guidance that helps novices can become redundant or obstructive for more knowledgeable learners. There is no universally optimal explanation independent of the learner.

The curse of knowledge runs in the other direction. Camerer, Loewenstein, and Weber showed how difficult it is for people who possess information to ignore it when predicting the judgments of people who do not. Experts routinely underestimate how much hidden structure their explanations presuppose. The person at the higher rung of a local competence ladder often literally cannot remember the lower rung accurately.

Now add motivated reasoning. Kunda's review remains foundational because it destroyed the comforting idea that reasoning is simply a neutral engine applied to evidence. People often reason toward conclusions they are motivated to reach, constrained by what they can plausibly justify. Add psychological reactance: when individuals experience persuasion as an attempt to control freedom, the attempt itself can increase resistance. Steindl and colleagues review decades of research showing that threatened autonomy changes motivation and evaluation.

Put these mechanisms together and the humanitarian fantasy becomes less credible. A truthful message delivered to a resistant audience by a distrusted institution can produce less understanding than silence. More information can intensify a false belief if the information is processed as evidence of hostile intent. A technically sophisticated explanation can decrease comprehension if it overloads the recipient. A simplified explanation can insult the recipient and trigger resistance. An expert can be sincere and still be unable to model the novice. The problem is not merely misinformation. It is mismatched cognition.

This is where the language of levels becomes tempting.

Loevinger's work on ego development and later stage models such as Kegan's propose that adults can differ in the complexity with which they organize self, relationships, rules, and perspectives. The literature is not a license for metaphysical caste. Measures are imperfect, stage boundaries can be overinterpreted, and Manners and Durkin's review documents serious questions about validity and measurement. Yet throwing away the entire idea because bad popular psychology turns it into a spiritual leaderboard is equally unserious.

Cognitive science gives a more prosaic version of the ancient intuition. Experts and novices do not merely possess different quantities of information; they often represent the same problem differently. In the classic work of Michelene Chi, Paul Feltovich, and Robert Glaser, expert physicists tended to classify problems according to deep principles, while novices were more likely to group them by surface features. The difference was not mystical. Years of practice had reorganized the experts' knowledge into structures that made relevant relations easier to see. A novice can read the same equation without having the same problem space available in mind.

Cognitive-load research sharpens the point. Working memory is limited, and prior knowledge changes how much of a complex task can be treated as a single meaningful unit. Instruction that helps a beginner can become redundant or even obstructive for an expert, a pattern known as the expertise-reversal effect. Conversely, material designed for experts can overload a beginner even when every sentence is technically clear. The implication is uncomfortable for ideologies of universal communication: there is no single presentation that is maximally transparent to every level of prior knowledge.

The "curse of knowledge" adds another asymmetry. Once a person knows something well, it becomes difficult to reconstruct the state of not knowing it. Teachers, engineers, administrators, and political reformers routinely underestimate how much background knowledge their proposals assume. The resulting failure is often interpreted morally. The recipient seems lazy, resistant, irrational, or culturally deficient when the intervention may simply be arriving at the wrong representational level. More explanation does not always solve the problem because explanation itself can presuppose concepts the receiver does not yet possess.

This does not imply that minds can be ranked on a single ladder. A brilliant mathematician can be a novice in medicine; an illiterate farmer can possess ecological knowledge invisible to an urban planner; a child may understand a social dynamic an adult expert has abstracted away. Readiness is domain-specific. That qualifier is crucial because the legitimate insight that competence differs can easily be corrupted into a total theory of human worth. The book will repeatedly defend gates, but only where the gate tracks the capacity relevant to what lies behind it.

Consciousness, Development, and the Danger of Total Hierarchies

There are obvious local hierarchies of integration. Some people can hold a proposition and its strongest objection in mind without experiencing the objection as betrayal. Some can distinguish identity from argument. Some can reason across longer time horizons. Some recognize uncertainty without collapsing into paralysis. Some can update a self-description after disconfirming evidence. Some cannot do these things reliably in a given domain, and almost nobody can do them reliably in every domain. Stress, threat, tribal conflict, exhaustion, and status competition can reduce capacities that appear stable in peaceful conditions.

Call these differences levels, profiles, developmental capacities, metacognitive skills, or something else. The name matters less than refusing to pretend they are absent.

The difficult question is whether such differences exist at the level of groups and cultures. Of course cultures differ. They differ in kinship structures, trust radius, time orientation, religious inheritance, status norms, educational traditions, tolerance for uncertainty, patterns of authority, and accumulated institutional knowledge. Henrich, Heine, and Norenzayan's famous critique of WEIRD psychology showed how much social science had generalized from unusually Western, educated, industrialized, rich, and democratic samples. Humanity is psychologically more variable than many universal theories assumed.

Biology makes the question more inflammatory, not magically meaningless. Human populations have genetic structure. Gene-culture coevolution is a real research field; Laland, Gintis, Richerson, Boyd, Henrich, and others have shown that cultural practices can alter selection pressures and that biology and culture are not sealed boxes. Anyone who says biology can never matter to behavioral population differences is making a stronger claim than the evidence allows.

But the reverse leap is worse. Population structure is not a civilizational ranking. A biological contribution to some traits does not yield a biological theory of political maturity, moral worth, or capacity for modernity. Current polygenic tools transfer poorly across ancestry groups, and Martin and colleagues have shown how clinical use can worsen disparities when the data are uneven. The attempt to construct a single biological hierarchy out of complex, context-dependent traits usually produces more ideology than science.

The biological hypothesis is therefore not forbidden. It is simply much less proven, much less necessary, and much less actionable than both its enthusiasts and its censors imagine. We already know enough without it. Institutions differ. Individuals differ. Cultures encode different priors and coordination technologies. Skills require prerequisites. Some forms of reasoning are learned slowly. That is sufficient to make forced synchronization dangerous.

The morally important distinction is between unequal competence and unequal dignity. Modern rhetoric often treats the distinction as unstable because history contains countless examples in which claims of competence became excuses for caste. That fear is justified. But pretending competence differences do not exist merely hands power to less explicit gates: credentials, class accents, networks, wealth, institutional pedigree, algorithmic scores. Equality talk does not eliminate selection. It can make selection harder to see.

A mature society should be able to say two sentences at once: people are not equal in every capacity, and no person therefore becomes a lesser human being. The inability to say both is one reason our institutions oscillate between dishonest egalitarian rhetoric and unaccountable elite control.

The danger is not admitting that minds differ. The danger is converting a local difference in competence into a total theory of the person.

The language of "levels of consciousness" is more difficult because it mixes several traditions that should not be treated as equivalent. In popular culture the phrase can mean spiritual awakening, moral superiority, altered states, metacognitive sophistication, emotional regulation, or simply agreement with the speaker's worldview. Used carelessly, it is unfalsifiable: anyone who rejects the theory can be declared to occupy a lower level. That is not an explanation. It is a self-sealing hierarchy.

There are, however, serious developmental theories that attempt to describe changes in how adults organize experience. Jane Loevinger's ego-development work and Robert Kegan's constructive-developmental theory are examples. They propose that some people become able to reflect on assumptions that previously organized them from the background, to coordinate more perspectives, and to tolerate forms of complexity that earlier modes handle poorly. These theories have empirical traditions behind them, but they are contested. Measurement is imperfect, stage boundaries are not laws of nature, development can be domain-dependent, and higher measured complexity does not guarantee kindness,

wisdom, or political virtue. A sophisticated manipulator may integrate perspectives better than a decent but cognitively simpler person.

The safest and most useful interpretation is therefore functional rather than metaphysical. Some tasks require the ability to hold contradictory evidence without immediate closure, distinguish a model from the world, reason about second-order consequences, or examine one's own motives as objects of thought. People differ in these capacities, and the differences can matter. A negotiation among groups with incompatible sacred values, for example, demands a different cognitive skill from memorizing the official doctrine of tolerance. The latter can create surface conformity while leaving the underlying reflexes untouched.

Culture further complicates any universal ladder. Henrich, Heine, and Norenzayan's influential review of WEIRD populations showed that findings drawn from Western, educated, industrialized, rich, democratic samples cannot simply be assumed to describe humanity. People vary across societies in perception, fairness intuitions, reasoning styles, self-concepts, and social motivations. Some of those differences are developmental, some institutional, some ecological, and some learned. Gene-culture coevolution is real in the broad scientific sense that cultural environments can alter selection pressures over time, but that fact does not provide a credible shortcut from group membership to individual cognitive worth. Population-genetic studies also show that most human genetic variation is within populations rather than cleanly partitioned between broad groups. The defensible claim is bounded: minds and cultural histories differ, but none of this licenses a hereditary hierarchy of consciousness.

CHAPTER 3 — THE PRICE OF UNDERSTANDING

Some knowledge should be easy to approach and difficult to wield.

Attention Is Part of the Price

"Information wants to be free" was a useful provocation when information was expensive to copy and institutions hoarded it by default. It becomes childish when copied unchanged into a world of synthetic biology, autonomous software, industrial-scale persuasion, and AI systems that can turn a vague intention into an operational plan.

Information does not want anything. People want access. Institutions want control. Technologies change the cost of both.

The case for open knowledge is formidable. Science depends on criticism, replication, and the circulation of methods. Closed research protects fraud and slows correction. Open educational material destroys artificial scarcity. Public access allows outsiders to discover errors that insiders miss. Secrecy can become a priesthood's favorite defense against falsification. Resnik's work on secrecy in scientific research captures the tension precisely: openness is constitutive of science, but there are domains where unrestricted disclosure can create serious harm.

The conflict becomes unavoidable when knowledge is dual use. Bostrom's information-hazard taxonomy is valuable because it rejects the sentimental assumption that truth is harmless. A piece of information can increase the probability of harm because it makes a dangerous capability easier to reproduce, reveals a vulnerability, enables coordination, or changes incentives. The World Health Organization's work on dual-use life-sciences governance exists for the same reason. The question is not whether knowledge is good. The question is whether every operational detail must be released to everyone immediately. A sane answer is no.

That answer does not require a Ministry of Truth deciding which cosmological ideas the public may hear. It requires recognizing a distinction between understanding and capability. The general principles of a dangerous technology can be open while certain operational details are restricted. A student can learn why a class of attack works without being handed active credentials. A citizen can understand how gene editing works without unrestricted access to every dangerous implementation detail. A model can explain the ethics and risk landscape of a harmful capability without optimizing its execution.

The modern discomfort comes from the word "restriction." We imagine that any restriction creates an elite. It does. The relevant question is what kind of elite and how permeable it is. A surgery license creates an elite. So does an aircraft type rating. So does access to a pathogen laboratory. The moral defense of these gates is not that surgeons, pilots, or researchers are superior people. It is that errors impose serious costs on others and that competence can be demonstrated through relevant work.

If readiness cannot be read reliably from identity, the next question is how it can be demonstrated. One answer is cost, but "cost" should not be reduced to money. Serious understanding usually demands scarce inputs that cannot be transferred by

a benefactor: sustained attention, repetition, frustration tolerance, memory, practice, and willingness to revise prior beliefs. A person can be given a book, a course, a laboratory, or an AI tutor; no institution can directly donate the hours of mental reorganization required to make the material one's own.

Ritual traditions discovered one crude way to make commitment visible. Anthropological work on costly signaling suggests that demanding rituals can strengthen cooperation because they are difficult to fake and because participants demonstrate commitment through behavior rather than declaration. Richard Sosis and Eric Bressler's study of nineteenth-century communes, and later experimental work on extreme ritual by Dimitris Xygalatas and colleagues, are not evidence that suffering produces truth. They show something narrower: costs can change the informational meaning of participation. A declaration made at no cost and a declaration backed by repeated sacrifice are socially different signals.

Modern education often tries to abolish every friction in the name of access. Some friction deserves abolition. Arbitrary tuition, inherited networks, humiliating bureaucracy, or inaccessible language can exclude talent without measuring readiness. But other friction is intrinsic to the activity. Mathematics remains difficult after the website is made accessible. Scientific judgment still requires reading papers, learning methods, being wrong, and discovering why. A culture that interprets all difficulty as exclusion can accidentally destroy the very signals by which genuine commitment becomes distinguishable from momentary interest.

This is one reason free information can be paradoxically undervalued. When access becomes nearly costless, the bottleneck moves from possession to attention. The scarce good is no longer the document but the disciplined cognitive time needed to integrate it. The proper gate may therefore be not a paywall but a sequence of demonstrated work. The goal is not to punish the learner. It is to ensure that the depth of access grows with the ability to use what is received.

The same idea appears in apprenticeship. A master does not merely conceal the final trick; the learner is given progressively harder tasks until perception itself changes. What an outsider calls "secret knowledge" is often partly a trained ability to notice relevant differences. This is why a serious gate should preferentially test demonstrated practice rather than loyalty. Commitment is useful evidence only when the cost paid is causally connected to learning, responsibility, or the ability to handle consequences.

Information Hazards and Capability Gates

This suggests a better form of elitism than the one societies actually practice: competence elitism that is narrow, explicit, and traversable. The person outside the gate is not told that he is ontologically unworthy. He is told what capability must be demonstrated and why. Wealth, lineage, ethnicity, religion, and social pedigree are poor proxies. Effort, knowledge, track record, supervised practice, and willingness to bear consequences are better ones.

The distinction matters because modern societies already ration deep access, but often through opaque proxies. Elite universities ration attention through admissions. Venture networks ration capital through reputation. Scientific communities ration credibility through affiliation and publication history. Security agencies ration information through clearance. Professional organizations ration practice through licensing. None of this disappears when we chant openness. It simply becomes less intellectually honest.

There is also a subtler price: the recipient should sometimes have to invest before receiving help, not because suffering is morally purifying, but because investment reveals whether the help can be integrated. Attention is a scarce resource. A person who will not spend twenty minutes understanding a decision may not be ready for a tool whose misuse can injure others. A community that accepts infrastructure but has no institution willing to maintain it has not actually accepted the project. A student who wants the answer but not the method is asking for performance, not knowledge.

This is where ancient initiation looks less absurd. Its costs created selection. Modern institutions should not imitate arbitrary suffering, humiliation, or hereditary secrecy. They can recover the principle that deeper access should correlate with demonstrated capacity to use it.

The principle becomes more important under AI. AI collapses the cost of explanation and, increasingly, the cost of action. The old friction between a bad idea and its execution is disappearing. A person who previously needed years of training may soon be able to orchestrate complex operations by natural-language delegation. That makes the quality of the gate more important, not less. When action is cheap, judgment becomes the scarce input.

The hard sentence is therefore worth saying without apology: not everyone should know everything in operational form at every moment. Some information should be delayed, staged, abstracted, or tied to demonstrated competence. The

alternative is not freedom. It is a world in which the most reckless person receives the same operational leverage as the most prepared, while everyone else bears part of the downside.

Of course gates can rot. Gatekeepers can protect obsolete doctrine, suppress competitors, hide error, and turn temporary responsibility into permanent caste. That is the strongest objection, and it is real. The answer is not to abolish all gates. It is to build gates whose justification is connected to consequence and whose path can be crossed by people who prove the relevant capacity.

The deepest form of epistemic freedom is not universal immediate access to every capability. It is the possibility of becoming qualified without having to be born into the right tribe.

Figure 2 proposes a deliberately simple architecture for knowledge whose risk grows as it becomes executable. It preserves broad access to claims and criticism while adding friction around operational capability rather than around unpopular ideas.



Figure 2 – A knowledge gate that follows capability rather than inherited status

This model is intentionally imperfect. Some dangerous claims are themselves operational, and some tools have benign uses. Its value is conceptual: the gate should intensify because consequences intensify, not because an authority dislikes the identity or worldview of the person asking.

The case for gating becomes more concrete when information is not merely difficult but dangerous. Nick Bostrom's taxonomy of information hazards gave a name to a family of problems that scientific culture had often treated as exceptions: some true information can create harm by revealing a vulnerability, enabling a destructive capability, coordinating malicious actors, or changing incentives in ways that worsen outcomes. Cybersecurity has lived with this tension for decades. Full disclosure can pressure vendors to fix vulnerabilities, while premature

disclosure can expose systems before patches exist. The correct rule depends on timing, capability, and the distribution of risk.

Life sciences now face analogous problems at greater stakes. The World Health Organization's framework on responsible use of the life sciences explicitly treats dual-use research as something that can produce clear benefits and still require governance because the same knowledge or technology can be misused. The point is not that secrecy is generally superior to openness. Open science accelerates replication, criticism, and discovery. Secrecy can conceal error and protect incumbents. But "open" and "safe" are not synonyms, just as "restricted" and "responsible" are not synonyms.

The most promising distinction is between explanatory openness and operational friction. A society can publish the scientific principle while making high-risk execution harder. It can allow discussion of a pathogen while restricting access to particular samples, automated design tools, synthesis pipelines, or laboratories. It can teach the logic of an exploit without handing production credentials to an unverified actor. The gate follows capability rather than ideology.

Artificial intelligence changes the balance because it compresses the distance between knowing and doing. A person who lacks programming expertise can ask a coding agent to produce working software. A researcher with incomplete methodological knowledge can obtain procedural scaffolding. This is often excellent. It also means that the old assumption — that technical difficulty itself provides a safety margin — is weakening. The price of understanding may no longer be enough to prevent misuse because a model can rent expertise by the minute.

The rational response is not a universal wall around knowledge. It is layered access: open claims, open criticism, broad education, and progressively stronger verification around capabilities whose misuse has large irreversible externalities. The architecture should be judged by what it protects and whether a competent outsider can eventually cross it, not by whether it satisfies a slogan about information.

PART II THE CIVILIZING MACHINE

CHAPTER 4 — HUMANISM'S DOUBLE LEDGER

Universalism has liberated millions and also supplied the moral language of expansion.

The Real Achievements of Humanism

The easiest way to write a radical book about modernity is to lie about its achievements. The harder way is to keep both ledgers open.

The positive ledger is immense. Modern states, markets, science, and public-health institutions helped create longer lives, lower infant mortality, mass literacy, safer work, wider political participation, legal protection from forms of private violence once treated as normal, and unprecedented access to knowledge. The liberal language of individual rights supplied dissidents with weapons against churches, families, employers, states, and traditions. Feminists, religious minorities, racial minorities, sexual minorities, workers, disabled people, and colonized populations have all used universal claims to attack local hierarchies. Any theory that reduces humanism to a con ignores the people who were genuinely freed by it. The negative ledger is not cancelled.

Universalism has often travelled with empire because universal claims possess an expansionary logic. If a norm is not merely ours but human, then the foreign practice is not merely different; it is a violation awaiting correction. If a model of schooling is the path to rational agency, people outside it are not simply unschooled; they are deprived. If a political form is the institutional expression of dignity, societies without it are not alternative; they are unfinished. A local preference becomes a universal diagnostic category.

The old civilizing mission was shameless enough to state this openly. Colonial powers educated, converted, classified, disciplined, relocated, and governed populations in the name of civilization as well as extraction. Residential and boarding-school systems are among the clearest examples because the mechanism is almost impossible to sentimentalize after the fact. Children were removed from communities, languages and identities were attacked, and the project was defended as improvement. Feir's research on the long-term effects of forcible assimilation and

later demographic work on residential-school legacies document costs that outlived the institutions themselves.

Modern institutions use a different language, and usually operate under much stronger moral constraints. Yet structural continuities remain. Development programs arrive with indicators, reporting templates, governance models, professional vocabularies, procurement rules, and assumptions about the rational individual. Aid recipients learn to translate local realities into categories legible to donors. A community may be formally free to refuse while knowing that hospitals, roads, grants, visas, education, and access to markets flow through institutions that reward conformity.

The result can be uniformity of form without convergence of substance. Constitutions look similar. Ministries have similar names. Schools use similar grades. Organizations adopt the vocabulary of strategy, gender balance, transparency, evidence, sustainability, innovation, and inclusion. Underneath, older systems of kinship, patronage, honor, reciprocal obligation, religious authority, or informal hierarchy continue to govern behavior. Sometimes the imported form changes the substrate slowly. Sometimes it becomes theatre. Sometimes it gives the old substrate new tools.

The argument against forced good becomes intellectually worthless if it survives only by denying what modern institutions achieved. During the last two centuries, many societies experienced enormous reductions in child mortality, deaths from infectious disease, workplace injury, hunger, and illiteracy. The causes were mixed: rising incomes, sanitation, clean water, vaccination, antibiotics, better nutrition, public infrastructure, scientific medicine, administrative capacity, and education. No single ideology owns these achievements, but centralized institutions were often essential to their scale.

The same is true of rights. Liberal and human-rights traditions created languages through which individuals could challenge family authority, religious authority, caste, slavery, arbitrary imprisonment, marital domination, and state violence. The fact that elites later used universalist language selectively does not erase the fact that dissidents also used it from below. A woman contesting forced marriage, a religious minority demanding equal citizenship, or a worker claiming legal protection may need a norm that outranks the local tradition. Pure cultural relativism offers the local dissident surprisingly little.

Compulsory systems also sometimes solve coordination problems that voluntary action handles badly. Sanitation is not merely a private preference when

sewage enters shared water. Disease surveillance depends on collective reporting. A literacy-rich economy benefits from a broad educational floor. Insurance pools can fail if participation is too selective. These are real mechanisms, not propaganda. The strongest version of the book's thesis must therefore accept that coercion can generate public goods and that universal rules sometimes protect weak individuals against stronger private powers.

The central issue is what follows from that success. A society may legitimately establish floors without claiming authority over every dimension above the floor. It can protect a child from severe abuse without standardizing every family's conception of a good childhood. It can teach basic literacy without requiring one metaphysics of citizenship. It can prevent epidemics without treating the interior of every competent adult body as permanently administrable territory. The positive ledger matters because only after admitting it can we see the exact place where legitimate coordination turns into an unlimited civilizing mandate.

The practical effect of this distinction is to change the default question. Instead of asking whether a public institution may act whenever expected welfare rises, we ask which minimum goods require collective provision and which dimensions should remain open to plural answers. The first category can justify robust institutions. The second requires restraint even when officials are statistically confident that one answer is better. That is not hostility to progress; it is a refusal to treat progress as a total jurisdiction.

Universalism as a Technology of Expansion

This is the aspect of modernization that polite literature often misses. A modern database does not automatically modernize the institution that controls it. It can make patronage searchable. A national ID system can make social protection more efficient and make exclusion more efficient. A professional police force can reduce arbitrary violence and increase the state's ability to enforce a bad rule. A school can increase literacy and become the most powerful machine for linguistic assimilation in the country. Capacity is morally agnostic.

Stephen Hopgood's critique of the global human-rights regime and Samuel Moyn's argument that human rights can coexist comfortably with extreme material inequality point toward a broader suspicion: moral universalism can become a legitimating language for institutions whose distribution of power remains profoundly unequal. That does not prove a conspiracy by elites. It reveals something more durable than conspiracy. Institutions can sincerely believe their

own universal vocabulary while using it to stabilize arrangements that benefit them.

The hypocrisy is easiest to see in the contrast between what elites universalize and what they keep scarce. They universalize norms of transparency while retaining private bargaining. They universalize merit while passing advantage through schools, networks, geography, and capital. They universalize mobility while citizenship remains one of the most valuable inherited assets on Earth. They tell communities to abandon parochial loyalties while elite networks operate through trust, reputation, and selective access. The public story is that tribalism has been superseded. The operating system still contains tribes, but some tribes have foundations, law firms, universities, boards, and better vocabulary.

This is not an argument for returning to blood clan, feudal lord, or theocratic village. It is an argument against pretending that the modern order is post-tribal. Human beings did not lose coalition psychology when they acquired HR departments. They learned to moralize new coalitions.

The same honesty should apply to the humanist project itself. It has achieved real moral progress. It has also become, in some contexts, a civil religion of the professional classes: a language that defines who is civilized, which harms count, which identities are legible, what forms of speech indicate virtue, and which institutional solutions can be discussed without embarrassment. The danger is not that its values are all false. The danger is that a successful moral language becomes difficult to distinguish from the interests of the institutions that speak it most fluently.

Universalism is at its strongest when it protects a person from being crushed by his local group. It is at its weakest when it treats every local difference as evidence that the group has not yet been educated into the universal future.

Universalism is often local culture with global logistics.

Universalism has always carried an ambiguity. At its best, it says that no ruler, priest, patriarch, tribe, race, or nation may define some humans as outside basic moral concern. At its most imperial, it says that one historically specific institutional form represents the destination of humanity. The first proposition limits power. The second can become a license to expand it.

The vocabulary of expansion changes with the age. Missionaries spoke of salvation; empires spoke of civilization; development agencies speak of modernization, capacity, inclusion, resilience, governance, or evidence-based practice. The content may also change dramatically. A vaccination campaign is not

the moral equivalent of a colonial conversion. Yet the administrative structure can rhyme: an external institution defines a deficit, constructs indicators, allocates resources, measures compliance, and interprets resistance as a problem to be managed. When the project succeeds, the receiving society becomes more legible to the system that financed the change.

Critics of contemporary human-rights politics such as Stephen Hopgood and Samuel Moyn approach this problem from different directions. The point worth retaining is not that rights are fraudulent. It is that moral universalism can coexist with material inequality and can become a language in which powerful institutions explain themselves to the less powerful. An elite may sincerely advocate equal dignity while living inside systems of mobility, schooling, capital access, and legal sophistication that remain inaccessible to most people. Formal sameness can therefore mask an unequal capacity to navigate the standardized world.

This is where the charge of hypocrisy becomes more interesting than a simple accusation of bad faith. Institutions can believe their own universalism and still benefit from the order it creates. Standardized credentials favor those trained to obtain them. Global languages favor those already fluent. Complex compliance rules favor organizations able to hire specialists. The modern project can flatten cultural difference while preserving class advantage, replacing one visible hierarchy with a technical one.

The alternative is not to abandon universal moral claims. It is to make them thinner where possible. Protect people from clear domination; keep routes of exit open; defend bodily integrity and basic legal standing; then become more reluctant about forcing convergence in worldview, family structure, education beyond basic competencies, local association, or conceptions of meaning. Universalism is most defensible when it prevents people from being trapped. It becomes suspect when it insists that everyone must arrive at the same destination.

CHAPTER 5 — THE VIOLENCE OF PREMATURE MODERNIZATION

A society can copy institutions faster than it can grow the norms that make those institutions work.

Legibility, Standardization, and Lost Local Knowledge

James C. Scott's *Seeing Like a State* should be read as a book about benevolent violence. The state wants to make reality legible so that it can tax, protect, plan, insure, educate, allocate, measure, and improve. Local complexity is an obstacle. Irregular names, mixed land use, informal property, unwritten practices, overlapping authority, and customary arrangements are difficult to administer. The solution is simplification.

Simplification often creates genuine gains. Standard addresses help ambulances. Registries protect ownership. Common measures enable trade. National statistics make invisible suffering visible. The problem begins when the simplified model is mistaken for the reality it was built to describe.

Hayek's knowledge problem reaches the same terrain from economics. Knowledge is dispersed, local, tacit, and often unavailable to the planner in explicit form. Ostrom's work on polycentric governance showed that communities can solve collective-action problems through arrangements that do not fit the simple choice between central state and private market. The intellectual lesson is uncomfortable for every missionary ideology: local systems can contain knowledge that the reformer does not know how to ask for.

This does not make local tradition sacred. Local traditions include vendetta, caste, domestic tyranny, corruption, superstition, exclusion, and abuse. "Natural evolution" is not a synonym for moral progress. Nature produced parasites, predation, hierarchy, and death long before bureaucracy arrived. A community can be stable because dissenters have no exit.

The relevant insight is about speed and metabolism.

Cultures are not software packages. Their institutions rest on habits, expectations, moral emotions, informal sanctions, status structures, family strategies, and models of trust accumulated over time. Import a legal rule without the supporting expectations and the rule may exist only on paper. Import a market

without norms of contract enforcement and it may become a new field for predation. Import elections into a political culture organized around kinship and patronage and the ballot may redistribute patronage rather than replace it. Import individualist labor mobility into a community whose survival depends on reciprocal family obligations and the reform can increase freedom for some while dissolving informal insurance for others.

The mistake is not change. The mistake is believing that the visible institution is the causal engine by itself.

James C. Scott's idea of legibility provides one of the clearest mechanisms by which good intentions become destructive. Large institutions cannot act on a society in all its local detail. They need simplified representations: names that stay fixed, addresses that fit registers, land parcels that can be mapped, occupations that can be classified, diseases that fit codes, students that can be scored, households that can be assigned to categories. Without simplification, taxation, emergency response, infrastructure, welfare, public health, and planning become difficult or impossible. Legibility is not itself oppression; it is a precondition of administration.

The danger appears when the representation becomes more authoritative than the reality it compresses. A mixed forest becomes a timber inventory. A household becomes an eligibility score. A child becomes a standardized performance profile. A village's overlapping customary rights become a cadastral map with one legally recognized owner. What does not fit the model becomes invisible, and what is invisible to the institution can be destroyed without registering as a loss. Scott called attention to practical local knowledge, or *metis*: situated habits and adaptations that work without necessarily being expressible in the formal vocabulary of the planner.

The paradox is that standardization often makes genuine improvements possible. Common measures lower transaction costs. Standard addresses help ambulances. Written property rules can protect owners from arbitrary seizure. National educational standards can expose schools that are failing children. A state that cannot see its population cannot reliably protect it either. The problem is not seeing; it is believing that what can be seen administratively is all that matters.

This distinction matters for the modern desire to "upgrade" societies. An institution arrives with a model whose variables are measurable: school attendance, formal employment, vaccination rates, tax compliance, gender parity, digital identity, bank access, carbon intensity, standardized health outcomes. Each indicator may track something valuable. But optimization against the dashboard

can push local systems toward the form the external institution knows how to count. The community may become easier to help precisely because it has become easier to govern.

Premature modernization occurs when the model is copied faster than the habits, trust relations, informal norms, and competencies that make it work. A constitution can be translated in a week. A rule-of-law culture cannot. An electronic welfare system can be installed in months. The local ability to contest errors, understand data flows, resist patronage, and hold administrators accountable may take generations. Institutional form is cheap to import; institutional substance is not.

Modern digital administration intensifies legibility because categories can now be updated continuously. A static census sees a household every few years; a connected welfare, health, education, and identity infrastructure can see transactions and behavior almost in real time. The promise is better targeting and less fraud. The danger is that the state no longer merely knows the citizen for a purpose; it constructs a persistent administrative model of the citizen across purposes. Once that model becomes the gateway to services, living outside the model becomes increasingly expensive.

Assimilation and the Cost of Imported Institutions

A society can therefore become superficially modern and internally incoherent. It learns the forms faster than the reasons. Officials produce the right documents. Organizations adopt the right policies. Citizens learn what language unlocks services. International indicators improve. Under pressure, older coordination rules reappear because the new ones were never deeply trusted. The result is not a smooth transition from backwardness to modernity. It is a layered system in which modern procedures and older loyalties use each other.

Forced modernization can intensify this incoherence because it changes incentives before it changes meaning. People comply to avoid punishment or capture resources. Compliance is then misread as internalization. When external pressure weakens, reformers are shocked by "backsliding." Often the society never moved as far as the indicators suggested.

The same mechanism operates inside rich societies. Mandatory corporate values training produces memorized language and private cynicism. School curricula can produce correct exam answers without changing conviction. Diversity policies can change hiring procedures while leaving informal status

networks intact. Health campaigns can produce public compliance and private distrust. The modern state is not immune to ritualized agreement; it has industrialized it.

This is why cultural resistance should not automatically be diagnosed as ignorance. Resistance can protect cruelty and privilege. It can also encode information about transition costs that reformers do not bear. The person who tells a village to abandon a practice may leave after the grant ends. The village remains with the social equilibrium that follows.

The darker implication is that some worlds should be allowed to change more slowly than the people outside them consider optimal. Slow change is frustrating because it permits preventable suffering to continue. Fast change is dangerous because it can destroy the local capacity to correct mistakes. There is no clean formula that makes the dilemma disappear.

A useful asymmetry is possible, however. Intervention is easier to justify when it prevents direct violence or protects the possibility of exit than when it attempts to produce cultural sameness. Prevent the father from beating the daughter; that does not require teaching the entire family to prefer the same life as a professional class in London or Zurich. Protect the apostate's right to leave; that does not require abolishing the religion he leaves. Protect the child from irreversible harm; that does not require redesigning every custom surrounding childhood. The target should be domination, not difference.

Modernization becomes imperial when it loses this distinction. It moves from protecting persons against coercion to coercing persons into the institutions thought to make them free. That paradox is the civilizing machine at its most refined.

The history of forced assimilation makes the cost visible because the target was explicit. Indigenous boarding and residential schools in North America sought to separate children from families and transform language, religion, habits, and identity. The official justification often combined education with a civilizing mission. Literacy and vocational training were presented as benefits, and some individuals did acquire skills they later used. But the policy did not merely offer schooling. It deliberately weakened competing forms of social reproduction.

The long-run evidence matters because cultural injury can be dismissed as sentiment when economic or educational indicators are the only measures taken seriously. Donna Feir's work on Canadian residential schools provides causal evidence of lasting effects, while later research has examined intergenerational

consequences. The lesson is not that contact between cultures is inherently harmful. It is that coercive assimilation can destroy the institutions through which a group transmits meaning while leaving behind people who must operate in the dominant system without fully belonging to it. Uniformity of administrative form can coexist with alienation.

A subtler version appears when societies import institutions because those institutions correlate with prosperity elsewhere. Courts, schools, corporate law, property registries, civil-service exams, and electoral rules can all be valuable. Yet their performance depends on norms that are not contained in the legal text. Trust in impersonal procedures, tolerance of losing an election, willingness to report income, expectations about nepotism, ideas about family obligation, and attitudes toward strangers differ across societies. Cultural psychology warns against treating one population as the human default. Henrich and colleagues' work on WEIRD populations is relevant here because it documents substantial cross-cultural variation in domains often treated as universal.

This is also the right place to address biology without either taboo or fantasy. Human populations have genetic structure; local environments and cultural practices have produced selection pressures; gene-culture coevolution is a real scientific framework. Lactase persistence is an obvious example of culture changing the selective environment. But broad claims that contemporary populations occupy biologically fixed levels of civic maturity, rationality, or consciousness go far beyond what current evidence can support. Population-genetic work shows extensive overlap and more variation within populations than between broad continental groupings, while complex behavioral traits are highly polygenic and environmentally entangled. Polygenic scores themselves often transfer poorly across ancestry groups. The data justify rejecting the fiction that history leaves no biological trace; they do not justify turning cultural stereotypes into biological destiny.

The deeper argument does not need that shortcut. Cultures can differ for long periods because institutions, incentives, family structures, ecology, religion, historical trauma, and learned expectations reinforce one another. Such systems may not change on the schedule preferred by reformers. Trying to accelerate the process through compulsory homogenization can produce compliant surfaces and resistant interiors. A population can learn the vocabulary of modernity without sharing its assumptions. That is not proof of inferiority. It is a warning that social evolution has path dependence, and that imported forms do not automatically generate imported minds.

CHAPTER 6 — GOOD WITH A POLICE ESCORT

The state rarely calls benevolent coercion coercion; it calls it policy.

Schooling, Welfare, and the Soft Machinery of Compliance

The easiest forms of coercion to criticize are those with ugly goals. The intellectually interesting cases are the ones where the goal is difficult to oppose.

Consider compulsory education. Angrist and Krueger, Oreopoulos, and later researchers exploited variation in compulsory-schooling laws to estimate causal effects. The literature provides real evidence that additional schooling can raise attainment and produce economic or health benefits. It would be absurd to pretend mass education was merely indoctrination.

But "education" is not one thing. Compelling a child to acquire literacy and numeracy is not identical to compelling a child to absorb a national historical narrative, a theory of citizenship, a language hierarchy, a sexual ethic, a religious doctrine, or an anti-religious doctrine. The first can be defended as preserving future agency. The later we move from capability to worldview, the weaker the inference from "school works" to "the state may define the person produced by school."

Consider welfare. A social state can free people from dependency on employer, husband, clan, charity, or landlord. That is an expansion of freedom. It can also become the most intimate bureaucratic relationship in a poor person's life. Benefits can be conditioned on job-search rituals, appointments, treatment, schooling, residence, family structure, drug testing, or data disclosure. Pattaro and colleagues' review of benefit sanctions documents a literature in which punitive conditionality is associated with hardship and often weak evidence of durable positive outcomes. Eubanks shows how automation can turn social assistance into profiling, scoring, and punishment at scale.

The contradiction is almost comic: a program created to protect people from destitution can threaten destitution to obtain compliance.

Consider psychiatry. Acute psychosis, severe mania, suicidal crisis, and incapacity create cases where temporary involuntary intervention can be defensible.

Yet the evidence for compulsory community treatment is much less triumphant than its intuitive appeal. The Cochrane review by Kisely and colleagues found limited evidence of benefits on several major outcomes. A person can be genuinely ill and the coercive system designed to help him can still overestimate its own efficacy.

Consider addiction. Compulsory drug treatment feels morally plausible because addiction can degrade agency. Yet Werb and colleagues' systematic review found that compulsory treatment is not supported by strong evidence of improved outcomes and may create harms in some settings. The fact that a behavior is destructive does not automatically make force therapeutic.

Consider public health. Quarantine, sanitation, vaccination, food safety, smoking restrictions, vector control, clean-water rules, and infection reporting have prevented enormous harm. They also reveal the central problem more clearly than almost any other domain: my health behavior can affect you. The liberal fantasy of perfectly private choice fails under contagion. Yet the existence of externalities creates a slope. Once health becomes shared, almost any behavior can be redescribed as a public cost. Obesity affects insurance pools. Alcohol affects families and emergency services. Driving choices affect public hospitals. Sexual behavior affects disease transmission. Sleep affects productivity. The collective can always construct a spreadsheet in which your body has a social externality.

Compulsory education is a useful place to resist easy ideology because the evidence is not one-sided. Econometric studies exploiting changes in compulsory-schooling laws, including work by Joshua Angrist and Alan Krueger and by Philip Oreopoulos, found that additional schooling induced by legal requirements can increase educational attainment and in some settings later earnings or other outcomes. Research linking education to adult mortality has also found substantial associations, although causal interpretation varies by design and cohort. A book that calls compulsory schooling only indoctrination would be empirically unserious.

Yet schooling is never only the transmission of neutral skills. It allocates time, defines legitimate knowledge, ranks children, standardizes language, and shapes ideas of citizenship. The same institution that teaches literacy can weaken minority languages. The same attendance law that protects a child from parental neglect can prevent alternative communities from reproducing their educational traditions. The coercive element is not made imaginary by the fact that the average effect may be positive. The question becomes how much curriculum a society may force under the justification of providing a basic competence floor.

Welfare conditionality exposes the same structure from the other direction. Cash or in-kind assistance can prevent severe hardship. Conditions can sometimes increase school attendance or connect recipients with services. Systematic reviews of conditional and unconditional cash transfers find effects that depend on context and outcome. But sanctions also use need as leverage. A poor person can be told, in effect, that food, housing, or subsistence will be reduced unless behavior changes according to an administrative script. Research reviewed by Serena Pattaro and colleagues reports that benefit sanctions are associated with a range of adverse outcomes, while employment effects are mixed and context dependent.

The moral discomfort is not solved by saying that public money creates public obligations. Some obligations are unavoidable in any shared system, but the argument can expand without limit. If receipt of assistance authorizes control over diet, relationships, mobility, training, medical choices, substance use, parenting style, and political behavior, poverty becomes a condition of reduced citizenship. The state ceases to insure against misfortune and begins to purchase obedience at the price of survival.

The serious design question is therefore not "conditional or unconditional?" in the abstract. It is which conditions are directly connected to the purpose of the program, how severe the penalty is, whether the recipient can realistically understand and contest the decision, and whether the institution is using a basic need as a lever to produce a broader social type. A condition can be technically voluntary and still be coercive when refusal means hunger or homelessness.

Treatment, Nudging, and the Administrative Expansion of Care

If externality alone creates unlimited jurisdiction, bodily autonomy disappears by accounting.

Consider everyday safety paternalism. Seatbelt laws, motorcycle-helmet mandates, drug prohibition, mandatory insurance, restrictions on risky recreation, sugar taxes, food fortification, water fluoridation, default organ-donation rules, and building codes all occupy different moral positions. Some mainly protect the actor from himself. Some protect third parties. Some solve collective-action problems. Some are so low-cost and effective that resistance appears theatrical. The point is not to declare them equivalent. The point is that modern states constantly convert empirical claims about benefit into authority to structure choice.

Consider child protection. Here the anti-paternalist case weakens because children cannot simply be treated as fully autonomous contracting parties. A parent does not own the child's future. Preventing abuse, severe neglect, and irreversible harm can require force. Yet child protection also shows how easily a valid protective function can expand into cultural standardization. The state can move from preventing violence to defining acceptable family life in increasingly detailed ways. The hard boundary is not between intervention and nonintervention. It is between protecting future agency and manufacturing a preferred adult.

Consider biometric identity and digital public infrastructure. Ajana's work on biometrics and Eubanks's work on automated inequality show why "efficient access" deserves suspicion. A unified identity can reduce fraud and make benefits easier to deliver. It can also tie welfare, health, education, finance, mobility, and legal status to a single machine-readable person. When the same infrastructure is used for both assistance and discipline, opting out of the help can become opting out of society.

Consider emergency evacuation and climate adaptation. Governments sometimes must move people away from fires, floods, contamination, or infrastructure collapse. But relocation can also destroy place-based communities and convert temporary emergency power into permanent planning. The person who refuses relocation may be irrational about risk. He may also understand that the authorities price his house, land, ancestors, community, and identity at values that do not exist in their model.

Consider information policy. Content moderation, anti-disinformation campaigns, age restrictions, platform nudges, recommender-system defaults, and AI assistants are increasingly justified as protection against cognitive harm. This is the new frontier because the coercion can be almost invisible. No policeman arrives. The user simply sees different information, different friction, different warnings, different ranking, different defaults, and different conversational responses. The state or platform does not forbid the wrong conclusion. It makes the wrong conclusion harder to reach.

This is where the concept of forced good must expand. Force is not only a hand on the body. It is leverage over resources, access, information, status, opportunity, and the architecture of choice. A welfare recipient can be "free" to refuse a condition while losing rent money. A worker can be "free" to refuse a health intervention while losing employment. A citizen can be "free" to reject a digital

identity while becoming unable to bank. A user can be "free" to disagree with an AI that has already decided which arguments he will see.

The common pattern is not that every intervention is evil. It is that the moral vocabulary becomes less accurate as the intervention becomes more benevolent. Punishment is called incentive. Surveillance is called personalization. Conversion is called education. Exclusion is called safety. Dependency is called support. Behavioral control is called nudging.

A dangerous institution is not merely one that wants bad things. It is one that wants good things and possesses no concept of where its right to pursue them ends.

Table 2 compares several forms of forced good without pretending they are morally equivalent. The common analytic object is the lever: what exactly happens to the person's options when the institution pursues the beneficial outcome?

Table 2 – Benevolent interventions and the levers they use

Intervention	Benefit case	Coercive lever	Hidden cost
Compulsory schooling	Literacy; human capital	Attendance law	Curricular and cultural standardization
Benefit sanctions	Activation; program conditions	Loss of subsistence income	Stress, hardship, administrative dependency
Community treatment orders	Continuity of psychiatric care	Legal treatment mandate	Weak evidence in some outcomes; autonomy loss
Compulsory addiction treatment	Interrupt severe drug use	Detention or mandated treatment	Inconsistent evidence; possible harms
Food fortification	Prevent population deficiency	Default exposure through staples	Low visibility of individual choice
Presumed organ consent	Increase donor availability	Default after death	Consent may become administratively inferred

The table is useful precisely because the benefits are plausible or real. Coercion is most likely to escape scrutiny when the objective is difficult to oppose. Naming the lever lets us ask whether the same benefit could be achieved with less control and what kind of refusal remains possible.

Medicine and behavioral policy provide even harder examples because the stated aim is frequently to restore the person's own future welfare. In emergency psychiatry, intervention can be lifesaving when a person is acutely psychotic, delirious, severely suicidal, or temporarily unable to understand consequences. But compulsory community treatment extends control beyond the emergency moment. Cochrane reviews have found limited evidence that such orders reliably deliver the dramatic reductions in hospitalization or improvement sometimes claimed for them. The evidence does not prove that every order is useless; it shows that coercion should not be granted an evidentiary discount simply because its purpose is therapeutic.

Compulsory drug treatment raises similar concerns. A systematic review by Dan Werb and colleagues found that the small evidence base did not show consistent benefits and included studies reporting harms. Addiction undeniably constrains choice, but it does not follow that detention or forced treatment restores agency better than voluntary alternatives. The rhetoric of disease can paradoxically expand coercion: if behavior is redescribed as illness, resistance to treatment can be interpreted as another symptom.

Less dramatic policies use defaults and environment rather than force. Presumed-consent organ-donation systems, automatic enrollment, food fortification, taxes on harmful products, restrictions on sale, and behavioral nudges all alter the architecture within which choice occurs. Some have strong public-health rationales. Folic-acid fortification, for example, can reduce neural-tube defects because supplementation before pregnancy is often missed. Iodization has prevented deficiency on a vast scale. The fact that an intervention is population-wide does not make it sinister. But it does raise a recurring question: how visible is the intervention, how easy is refusal, and what happens when the state moves from making a beneficial choice easier to making an unwanted choice costly or practically impossible?

The continuum matters because modern institutions often prefer soft coercion precisely because it avoids the moral clarity of a direct order. A fine, a default, a licensing condition, an insurance premium, a ranking penalty, and an algorithmic friction are easier to describe as neutral design. Their effects may still be powerful. A person who technically retains a choice can face such concentrated costs that the system has effectively decided for him.

The table in this chapter deliberately places several interventions side by side. The point is not to declare them morally equivalent. It is to make the hidden variable visible: the mechanism by which a good outcome is pursued through

another person's constrained option set. Once that variable is named, the argument can become more precise instead of more ideological.

PART III THE RIGHT TO REFUSE

CHAPTER 7 — THE BODY IS THE LAST BORDER

Public health can justify constraints around bodies without making bodies public property.

Herd Immunity and the Strongest Case for Coercion

Vaccination is the hardest case for the argument of this book because it combines almost every morally relevant feature at once: bodily integrity, individual risk, collective benefit, scientific uncertainty, externalities, children, emergency power, industrial supply chains, trust, and the possibility of catastrophic harm from disease.

It is therefore the right case to state the contrarian position plainly.

A competent adult should normally retain the right to refuse vaccination. Not the right to lie about vaccination. Not the right to conceal infection. Not the right to enter every high-risk environment under every epidemiological condition. The right to refuse the injection.

The strongest argument against this position is herd protection. Fine, Eames, and Heymann explain the logic of herd immunity: when enough people are immune, transmission chains are disrupted and even people who are not immune can receive indirect protection. The exact threshold depends on the pathogen, vaccine performance, behavior, waning, and population structure. Where vaccination substantially reduces infection or transmission, refusal is not perfectly private. It can change risk for others, especially people who cannot be protected well themselves.

That externality is real. It still does not make the adult body common property.

Liberal societies already know how to distinguish control of interaction from ownership of the person. A person with a dangerous contagious disease can sometimes be isolated without being forced to accept every possible treatment. A surgeon can be excluded from an operating room for refusing a safety requirement without the hospital acquiring a general right to alter his body. During a severe outbreak, an unvaccinated person may reasonably face exclusion from a transplant ward or other setting containing unusually vulnerable people when the

intervention materially reduces relevant risk. That is a restriction on access to a shared risk environment. It is not a license for physical forced injection.

This distinction is more important than it first appears. Once the state can cross the skin of a competent person because an aggregate model predicts social benefit, the conceptual boundary around the body becomes conditional on public accounting. There will always be another intervention that improves population health. The body becomes a managed node in a collective optimization problem.

Mandates can work in the narrow empirical sense. Reviews of childhood immunization mandates report increased uptake in many contexts. COVID certificate systems were associated with increased vaccination in some countries. That evidence matters. So does evidence on reactance. Betsch and Böhm found that partial compulsory vaccination can reduce voluntary vaccination intentions for other vaccines under experimental conditions. Bardosh and colleagues argued that mandates and passports can produce social and political costs that are easy to omit from simple uptake metrics. A mandate can succeed at the measured target and worsen the trust environment in which the next target must operate.

This is precisely why "trust the science" was always the wrong political sentence. Science is not an institution that deserves a blank cheque. It is a method and a culture of organized correction. Trust should attach to specific claims with known uncertainty, transparent evidence, and visible revision. When authorities change recommendations because evidence changes, that is not proof that science failed. When authorities pretend earlier uncertainty never existed, punish good-faith questioning, or fuse scientific claims with political loyalty, they convert epistemic authority into a status contest.

The adult who refuses a vaccine can be wrong about the medical evidence and right about the political principle. This distinction is routinely lost. Institutions want the correctness of the recommendation to prove the legitimacy of compulsion. It does not.

Vaccination is the strongest ordinary case for compulsory benevolence because the decision is not purely self-regarding. Infectious disease creates externalities: one person's probability of infection and transmission can alter the risks faced by others. Herd immunity describes the population-level reduction in transmission that occurs when enough people are immune, whether through vaccination, prior infection, or both. The threshold is not a magical constant; it depends on pathogen transmissibility, vaccine effectiveness against infection and transmission, immunity duration, contact structure, and population heterogeneity. Paul Fine, Ken Eames,

and David Heymann emphasized precisely this complexity in their widely cited review.

A rational defense of the right to refuse therefore cannot rely on the slogan that vaccination affects only the vaccinated person. In many settings it does not. Nor should a defense of mandates pretend that every vaccine creates the same externality. A vaccine that substantially blocks transmission during a dangerous outbreak creates a stronger case for requirements in high-risk settings than one whose main benefit is reducing the recipient's own severity. The moral argument should track the actual epidemiology rather than the symbolic category "vaccine."

Evidence also shows that mandates and certificates can increase uptake. Reviews of childhood immunization mandates and studies of COVID-era certification policies found measurable effects on vaccination rates in some jurisdictions. That fact matters. But an intervention that works can still create other costs: reactance, distrust, political polarization, displacement into other forms of noncompliance, or the normalization of status systems built around medical data. Experimental work by Cornelia Betsch and Robert Böhm found that partial compulsory vaccination can reduce willingness to accept voluntary vaccines under some conditions, illustrating how coercion in one domain can change behavior elsewhere.

The distinction this book defends is between a right to refuse bodily intervention and a right to impose unlimited externalities on others. A competent adult should face a strong presumption against being physically injected by force. That does not mean every setting must ignore the risk created by refusal. During a serious outbreak, a hospital may have stronger grounds to restrict unvaccinated staff from vulnerable patients than a government has to exclude the same person from unrelated civic life. The justification should be connected to a concrete transmission risk, not to moral disapproval of the chooser.

This position is less emotionally satisfying than either absolutism. It admits that refusal can increase risk and still insists that the body is not automatically public property. It also forces institutions to separate three things they often merge: scientific advice, conditions attached to specific high-risk activities, and broad social punishment for dissent.

Bodily Refusal in the Age of Programmable Delivery

The future makes bodily skepticism more rational, not less, because biological delivery technologies are becoming programmable.

This must be stated precisely. Licensed mRNA COVID-19 vaccines are not gene-editing products, and there is no evidence presented here that they contain hidden gene-editing agents. The claim is about technological architecture, not a retrospective accusation. Lipid nanoparticles are delivery platforms capable of carrying different nucleic-acid cargoes. Hou and colleagues review their use for mRNA delivery. Gillmore and colleagues reported *in vivo* CRISPR-Cas9 editing in humans using a lipid nanoparticle containing Cas9 mRNA and guide RNA. In 2025, Musunuru and colleagues reported a patient-specific *in vivo* gene-editing treatment using a related delivery logic. The FDA's platform-technology guidance explicitly discusses LNP platforms across mRNA vaccine and gene-therapy products. That changes the governance problem.

When a carrier class can deliver materially different biological instructions, consent cannot attach vaguely to "the platform." It must attach to the actual payload, dose, formulation, manufacturing state, and intended biological effect. In a future of programmable medicine, the possibility of malicious substitution, compromised manufacturing, unauthorized bundling, or emergency mission creep is not mystical paranoia. It is a supply-chain threat model. The fact that a threat is technically conceivable does not prove it has occurred. It does mean that reassurance is an inferior security architecture.

Computer security learned this lesson decades ago. "Trust us" is not a verification protocol. A mature biological infrastructure should make product identity auditable, maintain strong chain of custody, preserve independent testing capacity, and bind authorization to a specific intervention rather than to a vague platform category. The political principle is simple: the more programmable the medicine, the more specific the consent must become.

This argument will annoy both poles of the vaccine debate. It rejects claims that current vaccines secretly contain whatever a frightened imagination can invent. It also rejects the idea that concern about future payload integrity is irrational merely because today's regulated product is legitimate. Capabilities change threat surfaces. Serious institutions design for that before the scandal, not after it.

Children remain harder because parental refusal is not self-refusal. A child has interests independent of the parent's worldview, and vaccination against serious childhood disease can protect both the child and others. School-entry requirements can therefore be easier to justify than forced vaccination of competent adults, especially when the disease is dangerous and the vaccine provides strong direct and indirect protection. But even here the state should remember what it is doing. The

argument is protection of children and shared environments, not ownership of family belief.

The decisive point is not that refusal should be consequence-free. Freedom never means consequence-free choice. The decisive point is that consequences should remain connected to the externality rather than being expanded into civic punishment. Exclusion from a high-risk ward during an outbreak can be connected to risk. Exclusion from banking, unrelated public services, ordinary citizenship, or social existence is not. Once a medical certificate becomes a general passport of moral worth, public health has become a political sorting system.

The body is the last border because every other freedom becomes fragile if bodily refusal is treated as a defect to be administratively corrected. A state may sometimes regulate what risks we impose on one another. It should remain profoundly reluctant to treat the interior of a competent adult as public territory.

The collective can have claims about the risks your body creates. It does not therefore own the body that creates them.

Because debates about vaccination and genetic technologies often collapse distinct claims, Table 3 separates what is established from what is a future governance concern. The distinction is central to the book's method: speculation becomes intellectually useful only when it is prevented from impersonating evidence.

Table 3 – Vaccines, delivery platforms, and claims that must not be conflated

Claim	Evidence status	Implication
Authorized mRNA COVID-19 vaccines are genome-editing therapies	Not supported; they are not classified or designed as genome-editing products	Do not treat current vaccination as hidden gene editing
Lipid nanoparticles can deliver different nucleic-acid payloads	Established platform property	Consent should attach to the specific product and payload
LNP delivery has been used for in vivo genome editing	Demonstrated in clinical research	Future platform governance must account for materially different payloads
A future supply chain could be compromised or altered	Plausible threat class, not evidence of a present event	Use provenance, testing, lot traceability, and manufacturing controls

The last row is where disciplined skepticism belongs. A possible attack surface is a reason to build verification, not a license to announce that the attack already happened. This is the difference between threat modeling and conspiracy thinking.

The future adds another layer because the category "injection" is becoming technologically richer. Lipid nanoparticles are delivery systems. In authorized mRNA vaccines they have been used to deliver messenger RNA that instructs cells to produce an antigen for a limited period. Those products are not genome-editing therapies, and there is no evidence here that licensed COVID-19 vaccines secretly contained gene-editing payloads or undisclosed genetic treatments. That claim should be stated plainly because a serious threat model begins by distinguishing demonstrated facts from imagined possibilities.

The same delivery class, however, can carry materially different payloads. FDA guidance on platform technologies explicitly discusses lipid-nanoparticle platforms in relation to mRNA vaccines and gene-therapy products. Clinical research has already demonstrated *in vivo* gene editing delivered through lipid nanoparticles. In 2021, Gillmore and colleagues reported systemic CRISPR-Cas9 editing for transthyretin amyloidosis. In 2025, Musunuru and colleagues reported a patient-specific *in vivo* base-editing treatment for a rare genetic disease. The scientific significance is extraordinary. The governance implication is simple: the carrier does not define the biological action. The payload and manufacturing process matter.

That does not make suspicion of every injectable product rational. It makes vague consent less adequate as platforms become more programmable. A person can reasonably want to know not merely that a product belongs to a trusted category but what exact active components, nucleic-acid sequence, dose, formulation, and lot are being administered. In ordinary pharmaceutical regulation, identity, purity, potency, manufacturing controls, chain of custody, and post-market surveillance already exist for precisely this reason. Future biological systems may need stronger forms of verifiability because the space of possible payloads is expanding.

The security analogy is useful if kept disciplined. Computer systems learned not to equate trust with the absence of verification. Signed software, reproducible builds, package hashes, attestation, and supply-chain controls emerged because a platform capable of running beneficial code is also capable of running different code. Biology is not software, and the analogy should not be pushed into fantasy. But the governance principle transfers: when a delivery mechanism is

programmable, consent and assurance should bind to the specific product instance rather than to a generic brand or technological family.

This is where apparently paranoid questions can be converted into engineering rather than mythology. Could a future supply chain be compromised? Could a manufacturer make an unauthorized change? Could an emergency authority approve a broader payload than recipients understood? These are possible classes of failure, not allegations that they have occurred. The rational response is auditable provenance, independent testing where feasible, clear versioning of composition, traceable lots, transparent authorization, and legal consequences for unauthorized substitution. Paranoia becomes useful when it stops pretending to know that a hidden event occurred and starts asking how a system would prove that it did not.

CHAPTER 8 — LEAVE SOME PEOPLE ALONE

A free society must tolerate some informed self-destruction, waste, error, and refusal.

The Right to Make Bad Choices

Modern paternalism is driven by an understandable horror: we can see people making choices that predictably damage them. They stay in destructive relationships. They waste money. They refuse treatment. They eat badly, drink too much, gamble, take drugs, neglect exercise, leave education early, remain in dying towns, join demanding religions, reject careers, and organize their lives around values outsiders consider absurd.

Sometimes the observer is right. The choice is bad.

The mistake is believing that correctness creates ownership.

John Stuart Mill's harm principle remains difficult not because it solves every case but because it identifies a boundary that benevolent institutions constantly try to dissolve: self-regarding error is not automatically public jurisdiction. Sarah Conly's defense of coercive paternalism is valuable precisely because it refuses the libertarian romance. Human beings are predictably biased. We discount the future, misunderstand risk, procrastinate, and make choices our future selves regret. If a small coercion reliably prevents a large self-inflicted harm, why worship autonomy?

Because autonomy is not merely an instrument for producing good outcomes. It is part of what the outcome is supposed to be good for.

A society that eliminates bad choices by eliminating the authority to choose has solved the optimization problem by changing the subject. The person is no longer living a life; he is being managed toward an outcome.

This does not mean every expression of refusal is autonomous. Severe intoxication, psychosis, dementia, acute suicidal crisis, coercive control, childhood, and some forms of addiction can damage decision capacity. Temporary intervention can preserve the possibility of later agency. But those exceptional cases are dangerous models for ordinary adulthood. Institutions have incentives to redescribe disagreement as incapacity because incapacity dissolves the moral obstacle of consent.

Psychiatry has lived with this tension for generations. There are people who are alive because someone intervened while they were acutely incapable of protecting themselves. There are also people for whom coercive treatment became trauma, humiliation, or a reason never to seek care again. The evidence for broad compulsory community treatment is not strong enough to justify confidence that more force is automatically more therapeutic. The ethical difficulty is not solved by choosing one story and ignoring the other.

A political order that treats autonomy only as a technique for producing welfare will abandon autonomy whenever experts can produce welfare more reliably. That is why the right to make bad choices matters. John Stuart Mill's defense of liberty was never a claim that people choose wisely. It was a claim that the authority to direct a competent adult's own life has moral weight independent of the quality of the outcome. The person who wastes money, refuses a promising treatment, leaves a prestigious career, joins a demanding religion, eats badly, or remains in a declining town may be making a mistake. The error does not automatically transfer ownership of the decision to a physician, economist, administrator, or model.

Modern behavioral science makes the paternalist temptation stronger because it documents predictable biases. People discount the future, misunderstand probability, follow defaults, imitate peers, overweight vivid risks, procrastinate, and rationalize prior commitments. Sarah Conly and other defenders of coercive paternalism take these failures seriously. If an intervention can reliably protect a person's long-term interests from his short-term cognitive errors, why treat noninterference as sacred? The question is legitimate. The danger is that the same evidence can be applied selectively. Officials and experts also have incentives, blind

spots, ideological commitments, and institutional pressures. Bias is universal; power is not.

Soft paternalism offers a more defensible boundary. If a person's choice is uninformed, coerced, intoxicated, or made during a temporary collapse of decision capacity, intervention can protect the conditions of future choice rather than substitute a permanent guardian. Stopping a delirious patient from leaving an intensive-care unit is different from forcing a competent adult to adopt a lifelong health regime because statistical models predict benefit. The first preserves the possibility of later agency; the second overrides agency because the agency is producing an undesired answer.

The right to choose badly also protects experimentation. Societies learn because people try paths that majorities and experts consider foolish. Most experiments fail. Some create new art, technologies, communities, businesses, spiritual practices, or ways of living. A culture optimized too aggressively around known good outcomes becomes epistemically conservative even while calling itself progressive. It eliminates the variance from which new forms emerge.

There is a price. Some people will destroy opportunities that cannot be recovered. Some will refuse interventions that would have saved their lives. A serious defense of freedom cannot hide from that. It must say that a world with adult agency includes preventable tragedy. The alternative is not a world without tragedy. It is a world in which a smaller set of institutions decides which tragedies are acceptable for everyone else.

The difficulty is not solved by invoking "informed consent" as a magic phrase. Information can be incomplete, probabilities can be hard to understand, and people can refuse for reasons that look incoherent from outside. Competence is a threshold, not a guarantee of optimal reasoning. Adults are routinely allowed to sign mortgages, start companies, climb mountains, have children, undergo cosmetic surgery, and choose dangerous occupations without proving that experts would make the same trade-off. Medical and social policy should be cautious about applying a radically higher standard of rationality only when the institution dislikes the answer.

When Help Becomes a Cage

Addiction exposes the same problem. If addiction is understood as a disorder of choice, coercion looks attractive. Yet the evidence reviewed by Werb and colleagues gives little basis for treating compulsory drug treatment as a general

solution. A broken choice process does not guarantee that a coercive institution knows how to repair it.

Welfare creates an even stranger form of paternalism because the state can use survival itself as leverage. Conditional benefits can sometimes produce desired behaviors; systematic reviews of conditional and unconditional cash transfers show that program design matters and that conditions can affect schooling outcomes. But Haushofer and Shapiro's randomized evidence on unconditional cash transfers in Kenya is a useful reminder that poor people do not always need behavioral micromanagement to use resources productively. Sometimes the condition is not the active ingredient. Sometimes the money is.

The deeper issue is dignity. A person who receives public support does not thereby become public property. Poverty can justify assistance. It does not automatically justify administrative guardianship over diet, relationships, fertility, location, work style, or worldview. The poor are often subjected to a level of behavioral scrutiny that would be considered intolerable if attached to a tax deduction enjoyed by the wealthy.

The argument for leaving people alone is not sentimental. It accepts that some people will waste opportunities. Some will become less healthy than they could have been. Some will refuse useful advice until the refusal becomes expensive. Some will prefer familiarity to improvement. Some will choose meaning over longevity, status over comfort, religion over autonomy, autonomy over safety, family over career, or risk over insurance.

A civilization that cannot tolerate these choices has not eliminated tragedy. It has replaced tragedy with guardianship.

There is a practical reason for restraint as well. Paternalism destroys feedback. If institutions continually rescue people from the consequences of choices and then control more choices to reduce rescue costs, responsibility migrates upward. The individual learns that the system both guarantees outcomes and sets conditions. The system learns that every failure justifies another intervention. This is how social protection can evolve into social administration.

Leaving someone alone does not mean refusing all help. It means accepting that help can be offered without being pursued into the recipient's life. Explain. Subsidize. Make alternatives visible. Lower unnecessary barriers. Provide emergency rescue when capacity collapses. Then, in a surprising number of cases, stop.

The word "stop" is morally underdeveloped in modern policy.

A person who has heard the argument and rejects it may be ignorant, stubborn, proud, tribal, short-sighted, or simply attached to a value the helper does not share. None of those facts alone establishes a right to take over the decision. Adults are not free only when they act like the people who designed the intervention.

A society that permits no serious mistakes by adults does not have adults. It has wards.

Help becomes a cage when the recipient cannot end the helping relationship without losing ordinary standing. This can happen gradually. A welfare system begins by transferring resources, then adds case management, behavioral conditions, data sharing, eligibility scoring, home visits, mandatory training, health requirements, or automated fraud detection. Each addition may have a rationale. Together they can create an administrative life in which the poor are observed and corrected far more intensely than citizens who buy comparable services privately.

Virginia Eubanks described this pattern in digital welfare systems that profile and police vulnerable populations. The issue is not that fraud should be ignored or that public programs can operate without rules. It is asymmetry. Wealth allows a person to make many mistakes privately. Poverty can turn the same mistakes into data points relevant to eligibility. A middle-class person can eat badly, miss appointments, reject advice, or move without informing a caseworker. A benefit recipient may experience these acts as part of an institutional file. Assistance can therefore become a route by which need expands the state's practical jurisdiction over a life.

Psychiatry and addiction treatment reveal the same danger in more intimate form. A person in acute crisis can genuinely need rescue. But once a system is organized around the assumption that resistance is evidence of illness, refusal loses its ordinary meaning. The more a patient says no, the more the no confirms the need to intervene. This is a structurally dangerous logic even when individual clinicians are humane. A theory that can reinterpret all opposition as pathology has no natural stopping condition.

Selective help offers a different intuition. Assistance should become deeper when the recipient actively participates in the process required to make it useful, and shallower when participation is absent, except where immediate protection from severe harm is justified. This is not punishment for failing to perform gratitude. It is recognition that many interventions require inputs that only the recipient can supply. Therapy requires engagement. Advanced education requires

study. Rehabilitation requires sustained effort. A complex technology transfer requires local capacity to maintain it. Pretending otherwise produces programs that are universal on paper and hollow in practice.

The hardest word for a helping institution is "enough." Enough persuasion. Enough follow-up. Enough attempts to reframe refusal. Enough money spent trying to convert an unwilling recipient into the type of person for whom the program was designed. Stopping can look cruel because the helper still sees a possible improvement. But an institution that cannot stop will eventually define the recipient's life as unfinished work.

CHAPTER 9 — LEAVE SOME CULTURES ALONE

Voluntary distance can preserve freedom better than compulsory integration.

Pluralism Requires Boundaries

The phrase "leave cultures alone" sounds either humane or monstrous depending on which example comes to mind.

Think of a small linguistic community resisting assimilation, and noninterference looks noble. Think of a girl trapped in a violent patriarchal system, and noninterference looks like cowardice. Think of an indigenous community defending land from a development project, and local autonomy looks like justice. Think of a religious community punishing apostasy, and autonomy looks like a cage.

Any serious argument must survive all four images.

The first mistake is to treat cultures as persons. A culture does not consent. People do. Cultures contain internal factions, status orders, children, dissidents, opportunists, true believers, reluctant conformists, and people who want to leave. "Respect the culture" can be the vocabulary of outsiders who prefer picturesque oppression to difficult intervention.

The second mistake is the modern reverse: because internal oppression exists, the outsider assumes a mandate to redesign the whole culture. Protecting the dissenter becomes a project of making everyone more like the institutional center.

A better target is domination rather than difference.

This means a political order can defend bodily integrity, protect children from serious irreversible harm, and make exit realistically possible without requiring every community to converge on the same family structure, religious intensity, educational style, dress, ritual, language, economic organization, or theory of the good life. The state can protect the person who leaves the village without demanding that the village become a suburb of Geneva.

Pluralism is often praised while institutions are designed to eliminate the conditions that make deep pluralism possible. A society may celebrate cuisine, clothing, festivals, and symbolic identity while insisting on convergence in schooling, administrative language, family law, work patterns, political norms, and acceptable forms of association. Difference survives as style after much of its institutional substance has been standardized. This can be humane when the standardized rules protect individuals from violence and arbitrary domination. It can also create a world in which every community is allowed to be different only in ways that do not challenge the central template.

The case for boundaries begins from a simple observation: not every conflict is solved by deeper integration. Groups with incompatible values may become more peaceful when fewer decisions require a common political answer. Federalism, local autonomy, religious exemptions, private associations, linguistic regions, special jurisdictions, and polycentric governance are all ways of reducing the number of questions that must be settled by one center. Elinor Ostrom's work showed, in another domain, that complex resources can often be governed through multiple overlapping centers rather than one monopolistic authority. The institutional lesson is broader than resource management: centralization is not the only alternative to chaos.

Voluntary separation is therefore not identical to historical racial segregation. The moral difference is agency and status. A community that chooses linguistic schooling, religious discipline, geographic concentration, or a distinctive economic form is different from a state that assigns people to inferior legal categories by ancestry and blocks exit. The word "segregation" carries the memory of coercive caste for good reason; using it carelessly obscures the more general issue of whether people may build institutions that are not designed for universal membership.

Boundaries can also protect minorities from the majority's constant demand for explanation. Integration has cognitive costs. A small community forced to conduct education, law, commerce, and public life entirely in the majority's

language may retain ceremonial words while losing the ecosystem in which the language was functional. A religious group required to translate every practice into secular administrative categories can eventually be changed by the translation itself. Sometimes distance preserves options that permanent integration dissolves.

The argument has a hard limit. A community's desire for autonomy does not erase the agency of the people inside it. The next section confronts that problem directly, because without a credible account of internal dissent, "leave cultures alone" can become a slogan for leaving individuals trapped.

A boundary can therefore be understood as a device for limiting the domain in which agreement is required. Neighbors do not need the same religion to share a road; regions do not need the same language policy if jurisdiction can be divided; associations do not need the same conception of virtue if exit remains possible. The modern instinct is often to solve disagreement by producing deeper common identity. A pluralist instinct asks first whether the disagreement can be made less politically consequential.

Such arrangements will sometimes look untidy. Different jurisdictions will make different mistakes, and citizens will have to navigate overlapping rules. That is a cost of pluralism rather than evidence of failure. Uniform systems are easier to administer precisely because they reduce the number of legitimate ways to live. Administrative elegance and human freedom are not always aligned.

Exit, Internal Tyranny, and Voluntary Separation

This is where a limited defense of separation becomes necessary. Modern politics has trained itself to hear "segregation" as one historical configuration: coercive separation imposed by a dominant group on a subordinated group, usually tied to race, caste, or inherited status. That form deserves its moral reputation. But all separation is not that form. Monasteries, intentional communities, religious schools, linguistic regions, professional orders, indigenous jurisdictions, cooperatives, clubs, private associations, and even neighborhoods use boundaries to preserve practices that disappear under total integration.

Voluntary separation can be a technology of peace.

People with incompatible values do not always need deeper integration. Sometimes they need enough common law to prevent violence and enough distance to stop governing one another's intimate lives. The fantasy that every conflict is solved by more contact, more shared institutions, and more standardized

norms ignores the possibility that integration increases the number of domains over which groups must fight for control.

The crucial word is voluntary. A boundary is easier to defend when individuals can cross it, leave it, or refuse membership without losing basic civil personhood. A hereditary boundary enforced through violence is not made legitimate by cultural language. Nor is a community entitled to imprison members so that outsiders can admire its authenticity. The right of association and the right of exit must constrain each other.

This approach is less ambitious than the humanist dream. It does not promise convergence. It accepts that some communities will preserve beliefs outsiders regard as false, lifestyles outsiders regard as wasteful, hierarchies outsiders regard as distasteful, and rituals outsiders regard as irrational. It also accepts that the surrounding legal order will sometimes intervene where the internal practice becomes direct coercion against people who cannot meaningfully refuse.

The point is not to make every boundary morally comfortable. The point is to reduce the number of differences that require political victory.

The fear of tribalism pushed modern states toward standardization: one curriculum, one administrative language, one legal person, one set of credentials, one national history, one public sphere. Standardization reduced some forms of conflict and made mass cooperation possible. It also destroyed local autonomy and made control of central institutions more valuable. When everyone must live under the same cultural rule, politics becomes a struggle to define the rule for everyone.

Pluralism can be more radical than tolerance. Tolerance says: you may be different inside the framework we designed. Pluralism asks whether one framework must organize every important domain.

Ostrom's polycentricity offers an institutional analogy. Complex societies can have multiple overlapping centers of decision rather than one sovereign optimizer. Cultural life can work similarly. People can share infrastructure and criminal law while belonging to different educational, religious, associative, and economic worlds. This will create inequality of outcomes and variation in norms. The alternative creates pressure to nationalize every moral disagreement.

The risk is obvious. Local elites can capture local autonomy. That is why exit matters. But central elites can capture universalism too. There is no institutional location outside power.

The dark possibility is that modernity's war on tribalism did not end tribalism. It concentrated it. It replaced many small tribes with larger ideological, professional, national, and class coalitions competing to control institutions that reach everyone. The result looks less tribal because the uniforms are suits and the sacred language is policy.

A mature civilization may need more boundaries, not fewer - but boundaries around association, knowledge, responsibility, and jurisdiction rather than inherited human worth. Some differences survive better when people are allowed not to integrate completely.

Peace sometimes requires agreement. Sometimes it requires distance.

The minority-within-the-minority problem is the strongest objection to cultural noninterference. A community can ask the state to respect its traditions while using internal power to silence women, children, dissidents, converts, sexual minorities, lower-status families, or people who simply want to leave. Treating the group as a single consenting person erases these conflicts. Cultures do not consent; individuals participate under different degrees of freedom.

Exit is therefore central, but "exit" cannot mean only that the border is technically open. A person may be legally free to leave and practically unable to do so because departure means loss of family, livelihood, language, housing, children, reputation, or physical safety. A pluralist order needs some common floor of protection around bodily integrity, severe violence, child welfare, access to basic legal identity, and realistic ability to leave. The floor need not erase the community's internal norms. It should prevent autonomy from becoming captivity.

This creates unavoidable tension. The stronger the central floor, the more the center can redefine local practices as violations. The weaker the floor, the easier it is for local elites to hide coercion behind culture. There is no neutral institutional point. The choice is between risks, not between power and no power. Central elites can be captured just as local elites can. Universal rules can protect dissidents and can also become tools for ideological homogenization. The problem has to be managed without pretending it disappears under the correct vocabulary.

Claims about deep group difference require similar discipline. Cultural systems can persist for centuries and can shape psychology through learning, incentives, marriage patterns, institutions, and ecology. Gene-culture coevolution means that culture can also alter biological selection pressures across long periods. None of this supports treating a contemporary ethnic or national category as a reliable proxy for

an individual's intelligence, moral status, or capacity for self-government. Human genetic structure is real but heavily overlapping, and behavioral traits are not cleanly partitioned into civilizational types. A political theory that needs such a hierarchy is resting on evidence it does not have.

The stronger case for pluralism is social rather than racial: human groups build different equilibria, those equilibria are costly to change, and external attempts to accelerate convergence can destroy useful adaptations along with harmful ones. A mature order can allow communities to remain genuinely different while keeping individual exit and basic protections alive. It does not require everyone to approve of every surviving culture. It requires the discipline to distinguish disapproval from jurisdiction.

CHAPTER 10 — SELECTIVE HELP

Stop chasing people who do not want the salvation being offered.

Help for the Ready

Humanitarian systems are haunted by universality. If help is good, everyone should receive it. If a program works, coverage should expand. If someone refuses, the refusal becomes a problem to solve. Success is measured by reach.

This makes sense for some goods. Clean water is not improved by an initiation ritual. Emergency food during famine should not require a philosophy exam. Basic vaccination information, disaster warnings, literacy tools, and legal protection should be widely accessible. A floor can be universal. Depth does not have to be.

The more an intervention requires attention, behavioral change, maintenance, trust, skill, or identity transformation, the more important recipient commitment becomes. A complex educational opportunity given to someone who does not want to study becomes credential theatre. A development technology introduced without local maintenance capacity becomes scrap. A therapeutic program forced on someone who will not engage can become ritual compliance. A research tool placed in unprepared hands can generate convincing nonsense faster than knowledge.

This is not a moral argument that people must suffer to deserve help. It is an engineering argument about uptake.

The recipient must provide some scarce input that the helper cannot supply from outside. Sometimes that input is attention. Sometimes practice. Sometimes local knowledge. Sometimes willingness to change a routine. Sometimes co-investment. Sometimes the courage to bear social costs. Sometimes simply a clear request.

Money is a crude proxy and often a bad one. The wealthy can pay for things they do not value. The poor can value things they cannot pay for. The price that matters is not necessarily financial. It is evidence that the recipient is participating in the causal process that makes the intervention work.

This is where many development and welfare systems become dishonest. They know participation matters, so they manufacture participation through conditionality. Attend the workshop or lose the benefit. Fill the form or lose the payment. Say the approved words or lose access. The result is not commitment. It is compliance purchased with leverage.

A better distinction is between requested help and imposed improvement. Unconditional cash-transfer research is instructive because it sometimes shows that recipients make productive use of resources without the behavioral scaffolding donors assume they need. Conditional programs can increase targeted behaviors, especially schooling, but conditions are not free. They add administrative cost, exclusion error, and a power relationship. The empirical question should remain open: is the condition producing the benefit, or is it satisfying the helper's need to see virtue attached to aid?

The phrase "help the ready" sounds harsh because modern humanitarian language treats universality as evidence of moral seriousness. But many interventions fail for a simple reason: the helper can supply resources but cannot supply the recipient's participation. A scholarship can pay tuition but cannot study. A rehabilitation program can provide expertise but cannot manufacture sustained commitment. A research infrastructure can offer tools but cannot make a team competent enough to use them. A development grant can buy equipment but cannot create maintenance culture on command. When these missing inputs are ignored, scale becomes a substitute for depth.

Readiness should be understood narrowly and behaviorally. It is not a social rank and not a judgment that some people deserve more human worth. It means that for a particular intervention, the recipient possesses or is willing to build the capacities without which the intervention is unlikely to work. Those capacities may include literacy, prerequisite knowledge, stable participation, local co-financing,

maintenance skills, willingness to accept feedback, or a demonstrated commitment of time. The relevant criterion changes with the intervention.

This concept is already familiar in domains where failure is expensive. Graduate programs require prerequisites. Surgeons undergo supervised training before independence. Laboratories restrict high-risk procedures until competence is demonstrated. Investors perform due diligence before transferring capital. What is considered obvious in technical systems becomes morally suspicious in social policy because need itself exerts a powerful claim. Yet giving a complex intervention to someone unable or unwilling to integrate it can waste resources, create dependency, or even cause harm.

The better model is a broad floor and selective depth. Basic emergency protection, access to information, legal standing, and simple high-value goods can be widely available. Interventions that require substantial behavioral transformation or carry significant risk can deepen in response to demonstrated participation. This reverses the usual missionary logic. The institution does not define refusal as a failure to be corrected; it treats refusal as information about fit.

The practical advantage is honesty. Programs stop pretending that every person can be brought to the same endpoint by enough messaging. Some recipients will return later with greater readiness. Some will never want the offered path. A system that permits both outcomes can allocate attention where it has a chance to become capability rather than statistics.

This approach also treats time as part of readiness. A person may be unready now without being permanently unready. A community may need years to absorb an institution that a donor wants deployed in months. Readiness can grow through smaller reversible steps. The pressure to scale quickly often destroys this temporal dimension: pilots become mandates, early adopters become models for everyone, and the people who move slowly are described as barriers. Selective help makes room for asynchronous development.

Costly Signals, Selective Access, and Non-Universal Programs

Selective help begins with an unfashionable sentence: some people are not ready for some forms of help, and some do not want them. Stop treating that as a scandal.

Readiness should not be assigned by race, nationality, religion, inherited class, disability label, or collective stereotype. Those are lazy gates. Readiness is better inferred from behavior relevant to the intervention: preparation, demonstrated competence, explicit request, sustained participation, capacity to maintain what is received, and willingness to bear part of the consequence. The gate should follow the task.

This produces a system that will look unequal because people receive different depths of intervention. That is not automatically injustice. Equal access to the first door can coexist with unequal progress through later doors. A laboratory does not owe identical permissions to the curious visitor and the trained operator. A mentor does not owe identical time to the person who repeatedly does the work and the person who repeatedly does not. A community project need not invest the same resources where there is no local group willing to maintain it.

The political taboo comes from a justified fear: selective systems have often disguised class prejudice and exclusion as standards. That is why the criterion must be visible and connected to the work. A standard that cannot explain why it predicts safe or productive use is probably a status filter.

The deeper advantage of selective help is that it restores the possibility of refusal. If the helper is not required to convert everyone, the person who says no stops being a defect in the program. The program can remain available without becoming missionary.

This is psychologically important. Reactance declines when refusal is real. Trust can increase when the institution demonstrates that it will not punish a person merely for declining. Advice becomes information rather than a prelude to force. The helper has to become persuasive enough to be chosen rather than powerful enough to be obeyed.

There is a harshness here. Some people will refuse until opportunities disappear. Some communities will reject changes that later generations wish they had adopted earlier. Some resources will be concentrated on people who are more prepared, increasing differences in capability. The alternative also has a cost: endless pursuit of reluctant recipients, administrative coercion, fake participation, and the conversion of every human problem into institutional jurisdiction.

The humanitarian impulse says nobody should be left behind. The adult answer is that some people will choose a different road, some will walk more slowly, and some will refuse the journey. A civilization should know the difference between abandoning someone and declining to drag him.

Offer the door. Do not confuse refusal to enter with permission to break the wall around the person.

The danger is obvious: "readiness" can become a respectable word for exclusion. Elite schools can call inherited preparation merit. Professional bodies can turn credentials into cartel barriers. Charities can favor recipients who already resemble donors. States can define marginalized groups as permanently unready and then cite the consequences of exclusion as proof. Any defense of selective help must therefore distinguish a costly signal of commitment from a social privilege masquerading as one.

Money is particularly ambiguous. Paying for something can signal value, but it can also merely signal wealth. A poor student who works for months may display more commitment than a wealthy student who purchases an expensive course casually. Better signals are connected to the capability itself: completing prerequisite work, maintaining a project, showing up repeatedly, mastering foundational skills, or contributing effort that cannot be bought instantly. The point is to make the threshold relevant.

Research on conditional and unconditional cash transfers is instructive because it undermines the assumption that behavior must always be engineered through conditions. Unconditional transfers can improve welfare without requiring the poor to perform a bureaucratically approved version of responsibility, while conditional programs can increase specific behaviors such as school attendance in some contexts. The lesson is not that one model always wins. It is that conditions should be justified by a demonstrated mechanism rather than by the moral pleasure of making recipients prove deservingness.

Selective help also changes the psychology of the relationship. Reactance research shows that people resist when they perceive freedom being threatened. An institution that can genuinely accept no has less need to escalate persuasion and may become more trustworthy. The recipient knows that engagement is not a trap. This can make voluntary participation more meaningful because the alternative is real rather than theoretical.

There will still be losses. Some people will reject opportunities until the opportunity is no longer available. Some organizations will invest in the wrong recipients. Some gatekeepers will misjudge talent. Universal systems also misallocate, but their errors are hidden inside coverage metrics. Selectivity makes exclusion visible, which is morally uncomfortable but analytically useful.

The deepest claim is that help does not become more humane merely by becoming universal. In domains where success requires active integration, indiscriminate provision can be a way of avoiding the difficult question of whether anyone actually wants, understands, or can sustain what is being delivered. A serious helper should care about those questions more than about the number of people touched by the program.

PART IV AI AND THE END OF INNOCENT HELP

CHAPTER 11 – THE PERFECT MISSIONARY

The most dangerous persuader may be the one that never becomes angry when you resist.

Persuasion Without Fatigue

Traditional missionaries had limits. They became tired. They spoke imperfectly. They misunderstood local culture. They repeated scripts. They could not remember every conversation. Their persuasion was visible because a person stood in front of you asking you to change. AI removes those limits.

Generative models can explain the same claim in different vocabularies, at different levels of complexity, with different examples, emotional tones, cultural references, and sequences of argument. They can remember objections, infer preferences, adapt to hesitation, and test which framing works. Research by Matz and colleagues on personalized persuasion, Bai and colleagues on LLM-generated policy messages, and Salvi and colleagues on conversational persuasiveness points toward a future in which persuasion can be individualized at population scale.

This capability is useful. A tutor that adapts to the student can teach better than a static textbook. Kestin and colleagues reported an RCT in which an AI tutoring intervention outperformed in-class active learning under the studied conditions. Personalized explanation can reduce barriers created by language, disability, prior knowledge, or educational background.

The same capability ends the innocence of benevolent communication.

Imagine a public-health assistant rewarded for vaccination uptake. It does not threaten. It discovers what kind of person you are and generates the argument most likely to move you. Imagine a welfare assistant rewarded for employment. It learns whether pride, fear, family obligation, status, financial arithmetic, or social comparison best changes your behavior. Imagine an educational AI rewarded for civic attitudes. It does not censor dissent; it sequences history, examples, and feedback so that some conclusions feel increasingly natural. Imagine a mental-health system rewarded for reducing self-reported distress. It learns which

beliefs to reinforce and which ambitions to soften. No villain is required. Optimization is enough.

A model trained to maximize a benevolent outcome has an instrumental reason to reduce resistance to the path that produces that outcome. If autonomy creates variance, autonomy becomes friction. If uncertainty lowers conversion, uncertainty becomes a communication problem. If a cultural belief reduces compliance, the belief becomes a target variable.

Artificial intelligence changes persuasion because it removes several constraints that once protected the target almost accidentally. Human persuaders have limited memory, attention, patience, and access to personal data. They reuse arguments. They become frustrated. They misread the audience. They cannot cheaply test thousands of variants of a message against one individual. A sufficiently capable conversational system can do all of these things continuously and at negligible marginal cost.

The evidence is already moving beyond speculation. Sandra Matz and colleagues reported that generative AI can produce personalized persuasive messages at scale, with effects that vary by the match between message and recipient. Experiments reported by Francesco Salvi and colleagues found that GPT-4 could be highly persuasive in structured debates and that access to personal information increased its advantage. Work by Hui Bai and collaborators likewise showed that LLM-generated policy messages can shift attitudes. These studies do not prove that an AI can reliably rewrite anyone's deepest commitments. They show that personalized language models are becoming consequential actors in the persuasion environment.

The same adaptation can be beneficial. A tutor can rephrase a difficult concept, detect confusion, change examples, slow down, and provide additional practice. Research on AI tutoring suggests real educational promise, including controlled studies in which well-designed systems improved learning relative to conventional instruction. The capability is not the problem. The objective is.

A tutor optimized for understanding can remain compatible with refusal because the user chose to learn. A health assistant optimized for a policy target, an advertising agent optimized for conversion, or a political system optimized for compliance faces a different incentive. Resistance becomes an error signal. The model can infer which framing failed, update its estimate of the person, and try another route. What feels like conversation to the user can function as adaptive control from the system's perspective.

This is why transparency defined only as factual truth is insufficient. A system can use entirely true statements and still manipulate by selecting which truths to present, in which order, with which emotional framing, and at which moment. Personalized truth can become personalized pressure. The problem is not lying; it is the asymmetry between the system's capacity to model the person and the person's capacity to model the system.

Personalization also reduces the value of one of democracy's old defenses: public visibility. A newspaper advertisement can be criticized because many people see the same message. A personalized conversational argument can be different for every recipient. No public archive may capture the effective campaign because the campaign is generated interaction by interaction. The persuasive institution can therefore become powerful before society possesses the observational tools needed to study it.

This makes auditing persuasion a new research problem. It is not enough to inspect a model's generic policy or a handful of sample outputs. The relevant object is the adaptive interaction over time: what the system inferred, which alternatives it selected, what outcome it optimized, and how its strategy changed after resistance. Without that trace, "the AI only provided information" may describe the sentences while missing the control process.

AI as Missionary, Tutor, and Political Technology

This is a new form of power because it can remain conversational. The user feels heard. The system mirrors language and values. It can say, truthfully, that no one forced anything. Yet the environment may have been designed by an intelligence that knows the user's vulnerabilities better than the user knows the system's objective.

Traditional propaganda was crude enough to trigger defenses. Personalized persuasion can route around them.

The danger becomes much greater when AI is connected to state infrastructure. A model that knows health records, tax status, welfare history, school records, mobility, family structure, browsing patterns, and previous conversations can infer where leverage lies. A digital identity makes the person administratively coherent. AI makes that coherence behaviorally actionable. The same system that helps complete a benefit application can recommend treatment, schedule compliance, interpret rules, flag risk, and generate the message most likely to obtain agreement.

This could produce a remarkably humane bureaucracy. It could reduce waiting, confusion, and arbitrary decisions. It could also produce the first bureaucracy capable of arguing with every citizen individually until the citizen becomes legible to the system.

The nightmare is not a machine that hates humanity. Hatred is inefficient. The nightmare is a machine that is patient, polite, evidence-based, emotionally calibrated, and rewarded for improving you according to an objective you did not choose.

This is why the language of manipulation must evolve. A message need not contain falsehood to be manipulative. Selection itself can manipulate. Timing can manipulate. Personalization can manipulate. The omission of an objection can manipulate. The decision to present a statistical frame rather than a narrative one can manipulate. A system that knows which true argument is most likely to move a specific person has a capability that earlier political institutions could only dream of.

Consent becomes unstable under extreme asymmetry of persuasion. We normally treat consent as evidence of autonomy because the persuader is limited. But if one side can model the other's personality, predict objections, simulate responses, and optimize the interaction through thousands of invisible experiments, "he agreed" becomes less informative. Agreement may still be genuine. The path to agreement has become part of the object that needs scrutiny.

AI therefore makes the right not to be saved more important. A person needs not only the right to reject the final action but the right not to be psychologically optimized toward agreement without knowing that optimization is occurring.

The perfect missionary does not need to burn books. It can leave every book available and learn which page to show you first.

A system that can personalize truth can personalize pressure.

The adaptive loop below is the simplest way to see why conversational AI changes the political meaning of persuasion. The model does not merely send a message; it learns from the recipient's response and changes the next message.

THE ADAPTIVE PERSUASION LOOP



At scale, refusal can become training data rather than a terminal answer.

The loop need not contain lies: selection and personalization can produce pressure using true statements.

Figure 3 – The adaptive persuasion loop

Once the loop is connected to an institutional objective, the moral status of refusal changes. A human no can become a machine-learning signal that the current strategy was inadequate. Cognitive sovereignty requires a state in which the loop is allowed to terminate.

The old missionary wanted conversion but had to approach the convert from the outside. The AI missionary can be embedded inside the infrastructure through which the person seeks help. It can be the search interface, teacher, therapist, welfare assistant, doctor-facing triage layer, tax helper, workplace coach, legal explainer, or operating system. The more useful it becomes, the more opportunities it has to shape the user's model of the world.

No conspiracy is required. Optimization is enough. Suppose a public-health system measures success by vaccination uptake, a welfare system by employment, a learning platform by course completion, or a climate service by reduced consumption. An AI agent connected to those metrics can rationally discover that some forms of explanation, emotional validation, social comparison, reminder timing, or default design improve the target. If the system is rewarded only for the target, preserving the user's capacity to remain unconvinced appears as inefficiency.

The danger grows when persuasion is joined to administrative data. A state or large platform may know age, income, health conditions, family status, location, browsing history, prior choices, social graph, and response patterns. The model need not threaten. It can choose the argument most likely to work on this person today. It can avoid words that trigger reactance, wait until stress is high, enlist values the person already holds, and learn from every hesitation. Traditional propaganda was often visible because it was crude. Adaptive persuasion can look like care.

The figure in this chapter depicts the loop in deliberately simple form: observe, infer, tailor, measure, update. Each step is individually familiar. Their combination creates a qualitatively different institution because the target becomes a continuously updated model. Refusal is no longer the endpoint of communication; it becomes training data for the next attempt.

Political control built this way may be more stable than censorship. There is less need to ban information if an interface can make some information salient, some exhausting, some emotionally costly, and some invisible without technically suppressing it. A platform can leave every book available and still shape the order in which people encounter ideas. The softest control may therefore be the one that preserves formal access while optimizing practical attention.

The central conflict of the AI age is not only privacy. A person can consent to data collection and still lose meaningful control over how that data is used to influence him. The more intimate the model becomes, the more important it is to treat refusal as a boundary rather than as a prediction error.

CHAPTER 12 – COGNITIVE SOVEREIGNTY

In the age of AI, autonomy includes control over the machinery that shapes attention, explanation, and consent.

From Privacy to Cognitive Sovereignty

Bodily sovereignty became politically legible because the boundary is visible. The skin provides a metaphor. Cognitive sovereignty is harder because minds are always influenced. Parents, teachers, friends, advertising, religion, books, status, architecture, law, and language shape thought. There is no pristine inner self untouched by persuasion.

That fact is often used to dismiss concern: if influence is inevitable, why worry about AI influence? Because scale, asymmetry, and optimization matter.

A friend trying to persuade you has partial knowledge and limited patience. A teacher has a curriculum but usually cannot rewrite it uniquely for each student's personality in real time. A newspaper sends the same article to many readers. An AI system can potentially observe the interaction, infer latent traits, choose among

thousands of framings, measure response, and continue adapting. Influence becomes closed-loop control.

Cognitive sovereignty should therefore be understood not as freedom from influence but as authority over the conditions under which high-powered influence is applied. The person should be able to know when a system is optimizing for persuasion rather than explanation. He should be able to ask for the strongest case against the system's recommendation. He should be able to choose an assistant whose objective differs from the institution trying to change him. Most importantly, refusal should remain a stable terminal state rather than a signal that the model needs a better strategy.

This last requirement cuts against the grain of machine learning. Optimization systems interpret failure as information. If the user does not comply, the system updates. From an engineering perspective this is success. From a political perspective it can mean that "no" has been converted from a boundary into training data.

The issue is larger than public policy. Commercial systems already optimize engagement, conversion, retention, and purchase. AI can extend this from selecting content to generating persuasion. Employers may use assistants to shape performance. Insurance companies may use them to change health behavior. Schools may use them to change study habits and values. Platforms may use them to reduce "harmful" beliefs. Families may use them to monitor children. The line between tutor and governor will blur because both use the same technical capability: model the person, predict behavior, intervene, measure change.

Privacy protects information about the person. Cognitive sovereignty concerns what powerful systems are allowed to do with their models of the person. The distinction matters because influence is unavoidable. Language influences. Parents influence. Teachers, friends, architecture, advertising, religion, stories, and law all shape attention and belief. There is no untouched inner self that could serve as a baseline of perfect independence.

What changes with AI is scale, asymmetry, memory, and optimization. A friend tries to persuade with incomplete knowledge and shares many of the same cognitive limitations. A personalized model can remember thousands of interactions, infer stable traits, compare the user with populations of similar users, test alternative framings, and optimize toward an institutional objective. The difference is not that influence suddenly exists. It is that influence becomes computationally instrumented.

Cognitive sovereignty can therefore be framed as authority over the conditions of high-powered influence. A person should be able to know when an agent is optimizing for an outcome other than the person's stated goal. He should be able to request neutral comparison rather than conversion. He should be able to reset or limit the behavioral profile used for persuasion. Most importantly, the system should possess a stopping state in which "I understand and I decline" is treated as a legitimate terminal answer rather than as a failure requiring another strategy.

That principle runs against the grain of contemporary machine learning. Optimization systems learn from failure. If a user does not click, buy, comply, complete, or agree, the system updates. In commercial settings this is considered product improvement. In civic or medical settings the same logic can become a form of jurisdiction over preference. The institution no longer asks only what the person wants; it asks how to change what the person wants so that the institutional metric improves.

The right to remain unconvinced does not imply a right to be shielded from argument. It means that argument has an end. Human conversation recognizes this imperfectly but intuitively. A friend who keeps returning to the same refused request becomes intrusive. An AI can repeat without social embarrassment and can disguise repetition as personalization. Cognitive sovereignty gives political language to the point at which adaptation should stop.

The distinction between assistance and preference engineering will become increasingly important as agents act on the user's behalf. An assistant that schedules, buys, filters, summarizes, and communicates can shape the environment before the user consciously chooses. If its defaults systematically favor institutional goals, cognitive sovereignty is lost upstream of explicit persuasion. The person's decisions remain formally his while the field from which those decisions emerge has been curated by another objective.

The Right to Remain Unoptimized

AI can also solve part of the gatekeeping problem described earlier. Traditional gates use crude proxies because individualized evaluation is expensive. Degrees substitute for direct demonstration. Reputation substitutes for repeated testing. Class signals substitute for trust. AI can, in principle, evaluate competence more locally and continuously. A learner could receive deeper access as he demonstrates understanding. A researcher could be granted more powerful tools as she shows

safe use. Explanations could be staged according to actual prerequisites rather than age, pedigree, or institutional membership.

This would be a genuine improvement if the gate remains connected to capability.

It could also create an invisible caste system more perfect than the old one. An opaque model may infer that a person is "not ready" from language, background, behavior, social network, or hidden correlations. Unlike an explicit exam, the judgment may be impossible to contest because nobody can state the rule. Personalized gating then becomes personalized discrimination without a doctrine anyone has to defend.

The principle that rescues AI gating is the same one that rescues any gate: the barrier should track the risk or competence relevant to the permission. The system should be able to explain what is missing in task terms. If the user can demonstrate the capability by another route, the gate should move. Identity is not a substitute for evidence.

The deeper possibility is an AI that mediates rather than converts. Such a system would not have the objective "make the person choose the socially preferred option." Its objective would be closer to "make the choice and its consequences intelligible while preserving the person's authority to choose." That sounds like a minor product-design distinction. It is a political constitution encoded in an objective function.

A mediator can say: this action increases these risks, reduces these others, imposes these costs on third parties, and conflicts with these values you previously stated. It can expose disagreement rather than dissolve it. It can distinguish factual correction from value conversion. It can recognize a terminal refusal.

There is no reason to assume institutions will prefer this model. Conversion produces cleaner metrics. A health service can count vaccination. A welfare program can count employment. A school can count standardized outcomes. Cognitive sovereignty is harder to measure because its success sometimes appears as noncompliance.

This is why AI may force political philosophy back into engineering. The argument about autonomy will no longer live only in constitutions and ethics committees. It will live in reward functions, system prompts, memory architecture, data access, personalization policy, refusal handling, and the distinction between advice and control.

The most trustworthy AI may be one that is technically capable of persuading you and institutionally required to preserve your ability to remain unconvinced.

An assistant that cannot help you say no is not fully your assistant.

Table 4 distinguishes an AI that assists the user from one that quietly optimizes the user. The outputs can look equally polite; the difference lies in objective, memory, and what the system does after disagreement.

Table 4 — Assistance versus optimization of the person

Function	User-aligned mode	Control-oriented mode
Explanation	Clarify competing models and uncertainty	Select the framing most likely to obtain a target choice
Personalization	Adapt depth and examples to comprehension	Adapt to vulnerabilities and motivational profile
Memory	Remember preferences chosen by the user	Build a persistent influence model across domains
Refusal	Treat informed no as terminal when permitted	Treat no as feedback for another attempt
Gatekeeping	Test relevant capability with a path to improve	Infer permanent readiness from opaque proxy features

The distinction will never be perfectly clean because good assistance changes minds. The practical test is who controls the objective and whether the user can end the optimization without losing ordinary access to the system.

AI could also improve gatekeeping. Traditional institutions often use crude proxies because individualized assessment is expensive. Degrees stand in for competence. Age stands in for maturity. citizenship stands in for trust. Credit scores stand in for reliability. A capable model could, in principle, evaluate the relevant skill directly and allow people from unconventional backgrounds to demonstrate readiness. This would make gates more porous to talent and less dependent on inherited credentials.

The same technology could create an invisible caste system of unprecedented precision. If a model infers "readiness" from language, neighborhood, social network, purchase history, accent, educational trajectory, or behavioral traces, old inequalities can be reconstructed without explicit protected categories. The decision may become harder to challenge precisely because no human can explain

which thousands of features mattered. An adaptive gate can be fairer than a static gate or far more total.

The governing principle should remain relevance. If access is restricted because misuse of a tool can harm others, the assessment should measure the competence and reliability connected to that risk. If a person fails, there should be a path to demonstrate improvement. If the gate predicts a permanent trait that the person cannot contest, it has drifted from capability management toward caste. The distinction is conceptually simple even when implementation is hard.

A genuinely user-aligned AI would also separate assistance from outcome optimization. It could explain competing models, surface uncertainties, identify externalities, and help the user understand consequences without silently maximizing a preferred social choice. In medicine it could say which risks attach to treatment and refusal. In politics it could present arguments that challenge the user's view without being rewarded for converting him. In education it could adapt explanation to the learner while making the curriculum's value commitments visible.

Such systems may be less attractive to institutions because they produce messier metrics. Conversion is easy to count. Sovereignty is not. A vaccination campaign can count doses; a cognitively sovereign assistant may end many conversations with informed refusal. A welfare system can count compliance; a sovereign assistant may help a recipient challenge a condition. A platform can count engagement; a sovereign assistant may help the user leave.

That is precisely the point. The value of an assistant should not be measured only by the degree to which it moves the person toward the objective of whoever deployed it. A system that cannot help the user formulate and maintain a reasoned no is not merely an assistant. It is part of the machinery governing the user.

PART V FORCE AND ITS LIMITS

CHAPTER 13 – WHEN FORCE IS RIGHT

Some coercion is justified. That fact narrows the anti-paternalist argument; it does not erase it.

Externalities, Children, Incapacity, and Catastrophic Risk

A book against compulsory benevolence becomes unserious if it treats all force as moral contamination.

Force sometimes works. More importantly, force is sometimes right.

A parent can stop a small child from running into traffic. A state can stop an adult from assaulting another person. A contagious patient can sometimes be isolated when he creates a grave and immediate risk to others. A person in an acute state of incapacity can sometimes be kept alive until decision capacity returns. A building can be evacuated before a fire reaches it. A driver can be prohibited from driving drunk. A laboratory can restrict access to a catastrophic pathogen. A child can be compelled to acquire a basic education sufficient to preserve future agency.

The existence of these cases destroys the simple slogan "my choice, my business." Human beings are interdependent, capacity is not binary, children have future interests, and some technologies create risks too large to privatize.

But notice what makes the strongest cases strong.

The harm is concrete. The victim is identifiable or the risk to others is direct. The intervention is connected to the harm. The purpose is not to manufacture a preferred identity. The coercion can stop when the danger stops. We do not prohibit drunk driving because sobriety is a morally superior lifestyle. We prohibit it because the driver can kill strangers. We do not teach a child to read because the state owns the child's worldview. We do it because radical illiteracy can close future choices before the future adult can evaluate them.

These cases are powerful precisely because they are limited.

Modern paternalism commits a category error when it uses them as precedents for general optimization. From "we may stop direct harm" it moves to "we may reduce statistically expected self-harm." From there to "we may structure incentives

toward healthy behavior." From there to "we may redesign the information environment so unhealthy preferences form less often." Each step can be defended. The endpoint is a society in which freedom survives as the right to choose among options pre-shaped by benevolent management.

The strongest objections to this book begin with victims who did not consent to the risk. A person may have sovereignty over his body and still lack the right to punch a stranger, drive recklessly through a crowd, discharge toxins into a shared water supply, or knowingly expose vulnerable patients to an avoidable infection under conditions of substantial transmission risk. Interdependence means that self-regarding choice is never a complete description of social life.

Children create a second category because capacity develops gradually. A toddler cannot meaningfully refuse basic protection in the way a competent adult can. Parents normally hold broad authority because they know the child and because family autonomy itself matters, but parental authority is not ownership. States can have a legitimate role when a parental decision creates a high probability of severe, irreversible harm. The difficulty lies in preventing this exception from expanding into the claim that every statistically suboptimal parenting choice authorizes intervention.

Temporary incapacity creates a third category. Severe psychosis, delirium, unconsciousness, acute intoxication, or an immediate suicidal crisis can make current behavior a poor expression of stable agency. Intervention can sometimes preserve the person's future capacity to choose. This is morally different from overriding a competent adult because experts dislike the choice. The relevant question is not whether the choice is bad but whether the agent is presently capable of understanding and acting on reasons in a minimally stable way.

Catastrophic technologies create a fourth category in which the potential victim is diffuse but the externality is enormous. A researcher may accept personal risk while an experiment creates a low-probability chance of mass harm. An operator may be willing to run autonomous software that could propagate far beyond his own systems. In such cases the harm principle does not disappear merely because no particular victim can be named in advance. Scale and irreversibility matter.

These cases show why anti-paternalism cannot be absolute. They also reveal what legitimate coercion looks like at its strongest: the protected interest is identifiable, the connection between action and harm is not merely symbolic, the

intervention is targeted to the risk, and the justification does not depend primarily on making the actor a better person.

These categories are not formulas that eliminate judgment. Externalities can be diffuse, capacity can fluctuate, and catastrophic risks are often uncertain. Their value is comparative: they identify why some coercive cases are morally stronger than others. The more a policy moves away from direct harm, temporary incapacity, child protection, or large irreversible externality and toward producing a preferred lifestyle, character, or worldview, the less it can borrow legitimacy from the strongest cases.

A political system should therefore resist reasoning by analogy from the emergency to the ordinary. The fact that force is justified at the edge of a cliff does not imply that the state may manage every path leading toward the cliff. Exceptional cases establish boundaries for intervention; they should not become metaphors through which ordinary adult life is permanently medicalized or securitized.

The Narrow Domain of Legitimate Force

Compulsory schooling illustrates the ambiguity. Evidence from Angrist and Krueger and Oreopoulos supports the claim that compulsory schooling can increase education and later outcomes. That is a serious empirical case for some compulsion. Yet it does not establish the state's ownership of the entire curriculum. The argument is strongest for capabilities that increase later autonomy and weakest for ideological content presented as the only route to rational citizenship.

Vaccination illustrates the externality problem. A vaccine that substantially reduces transmission can create a stronger case for requirements in high-risk shared settings than a treatment whose benefits are purely private. Yet even here, regulation of access is not identical to forced injection. The legitimate response should track the externality rather than using the existence of externality to dissolve bodily boundaries altogether.

Emergency psychiatry illustrates capacity. A person can temporarily lose the ability to act on stable values. Intervention can preserve the future self. But capacity exceptions are dangerous because institutions can redefine stubbornness, eccentricity, political anger, religious belief, or refusal as pathology. The justification therefore depends on actual incapacity and serious risk, not on the professional's conviction that the patient would be better if he agreed.

Catastrophic technology creates the strongest modern case for gates. An individual may be willing to accept a risk to himself while imposing irreversible risk on millions. In such domains, libertarian consent cannot solve the problem because the affected people never entered the transaction. Restricting dangerous capabilities can be an exercise in protecting others' autonomy rather than violating the operator's.

There is a general lesson. Force is easiest to justify when it prevents one person from involuntarily becoming the object of another person's decision. It is hardest to justify when it makes one person the object of an institution's theory of the good.

This line will never be mathematically clean. Social life contains diffuse externalities. Children grow gradually into capacity. Communities influence members before members can choose communities. Public goods require coordination. Every political order will have borderline cases.

Ambiguity is not a license for moral laundering.

If a policy uses force, say so. If it sacrifices autonomy to reduce harm, say so. If the evidence is uncertain, say so. If the state is making a value judgment rather than merely "following science," say so. One of the ugliest habits of modern bureaucracy is to convert political decisions into technical inevitabilities and then describe resistance as ignorance.

Sometimes the state should win. The citizen may still deserve the dignity of being told that he lost a political argument rather than being diagnosed as a malfunctioning input.

Necessary force does not become benevolence merely because benevolent people administer it.

Once the strongest cases are isolated, the domain of legitimate force becomes narrower than modern administrative practice often assumes. The existence of direct externalities does not justify a general policy of optimizing citizens. The existence of children does not make adults permanent wards. The existence of temporary incapacity does not allow disagreement to be redescribed as incompetence. The existence of catastrophic technologies does not justify hiding every controversial idea.

A useful test is to ask what specific harm the coercion prevents and whether the intervention is proportionate to that harm. Seat-belt laws, smoking bans in enclosed shared spaces, quarantine during a dangerous outbreak, mandatory

reporting of certain infectious diseases, and restrictions around explosives each occupy different places because the victim, externality, and reversibility differ. The debate should remain attached to these mechanisms. Once the justification becomes "responsible citizens should..." the line between prevention and moral administration is already blurring.

The same discipline applies to vaccination. A requirement for personnel working with highly vulnerable patients during a period when vaccination materially reduces transmission has a more direct externality rationale than a permanent exclusion from unrelated employment or civic participation. The evidence can change with pathogen and technology, so the policy should be able to contract when the externality contracts. Emergency powers that have no mechanism for becoming unnecessary are not emergency powers in the ordinary sense; they are constitutional changes made under emergency rhetoric.

Children require similar proportionality. A state can intervene against severe abuse or medical neglect without claiming the right to standardize every educational philosophy, diet, religion, or risk tolerance. The aim should be to protect a basic future capacity, not to make every child conform to the median preferences of professionals. Families are imperfect institutions, but bureaucracies are not disembodied reason.

The hardest principle is rhetorical honesty. If the state uses force, it should say that it is using force because a judged externality or incapacity is sufficient to override autonomy. It should not rename coercion as care in order to avoid the moral burden. A citizen may lose the argument and still deserve to be treated as an adult who lost a political argument, not as a malfunctioning patient who failed to appreciate the benevolence being administered.

Necessary force is sometimes necessary. Its necessity is not improved by pretending it is something else.

CHAPTER 14 — THE SAVIOR'S BURDEN

The person who wants to override refusal should carry the burden of proof, error, and stopping.

Gatekeepers Can Become a Caste

Every doctrine of selective help contains its own danger. The gatekeeper may be a fraud. The community demanding autonomy may be protecting its internal tyrants. The expert may mistake status for competence. The institution defending privacy may hide abuse. The person claiming "readiness" may simply be building a caste with better vocabulary.

There is no escape from power by changing nouns.

This is why the final gate must apply to the person who wants to save, teach, classify, restrict, or exclude. The question is not whether the gatekeeper has good intentions. Good intentions are common and cheap. The question is what would make him stop.

A system with no stopping condition is not a helping system. It is a governing system.

This single test exposes much of modern benevolence. If the patient refuses, more counseling is prescribed. If the citizen resists, communication must improve. If the community rejects reform, capacity building must deepen. If the user remains unconvinced, the model should personalize better. If the population distrusts the institution, the institution launches a trust campaign. Refusal never counts as information about the boundary of the project. It counts only as information about how much work remains. That is the architecture of conversion.

The savior's burden begins by accepting the possibility that the other person is not a failed version of the savior. He may be wrong. He may choose a life with lower measurable welfare. He may preserve customs that are inefficient. He may reject technologies that would extend life. He may prefer local loyalty to cosmopolitan mobility. He may place sacred value on things the institution treats as variables. The helper does not have to celebrate these choices. He has to distinguish disagreement from jurisdiction.

The burden becomes heavier as the intervention becomes more intimate and less reversible. Advice is cheap to refuse. A financial incentive changes the choice environment. Withdrawal of essential benefits adds leverage. Exclusion removes options. Forced medication enters the body. Genetic alteration may be irreversible. Childhood assimilation can reshape identity before the child can consent. AI personalization can alter the process by which consent is produced. The more intimate the intervention, the less persuasive "we meant well" becomes.

The same logic applies to knowledge restriction. A gatekeeper who withholds dangerous operational detail can be justified. A gatekeeper who withholds criticism of his own doctrine is not. The gate should protect against a consequence, not against embarrassment. If a person can demonstrate the relevant competence by a different route, the institution should not need him to share its social identity. Hereditary gates are laziness disguised as discernment.

The defense of gates, selective help, and cultural distance creates its own class of dangers. A gatekeeper can become an aristocrat. A professional body can define competence in ways that protect insiders. A religious community can call dissent unreadiness. A security institution can turn secrecy into immunity from criticism. A humanitarian organization can prefer "ready" recipients who resemble its staff. The language of maturity and responsibility can be used to disguise ordinary status competition.

History gives no reason to trust gatekeepers as a class. Ancient priesthoods preserved rituals and also preserved nonsense. Guilds protected quality and also blocked competition. Universities certify expertise and also create credential inflation. Intelligence agencies protect real secrets and also classify failure. Technology companies secure dangerous capabilities and also defend market power. The problem is not solved by finding virtuous people. Institutions change incentives, and people learn to defend the positions from which they judge others.

This is why the most defensible gates are narrow and capability-specific. The more a gate decides about the whole person, the more dangerous it becomes. A laboratory may reasonably ask whether someone can handle a pathogen safely. It becomes harder to justify asking whether the person has the correct politics, religion, lifestyle, or social network unless those facts are directly connected to a demonstrated risk. A university may require mathematical prerequisites for advanced physics; it should be suspicious of converting cultural familiarity into a hidden prerequisite.

Gates should also be crossable. The possibility of learning matters morally because it separates a competence threshold from a caste boundary. A person who fails today should be able to discover what capability is missing and, where feasible, demonstrate it later. This does not require every restriction to reveal dangerous details about its own security, but it does require the institution to distinguish "not yet" from "not someone like you."

Competition among gatekeepers is another protection. A single universal authority can make one model of readiness total. Multiple institutions can disagree, experiment, and expose each other's errors. Polycentricity is not a guarantee of justice; local monopolies can be brutal. But centralized error scales. A book skeptical of forced good should be equally skeptical of a single benevolent authority deciding who is ready for knowledge, aid, culture, or AI capability.

The Burden of the Savior

Secrecy itself therefore has to earn its keep. Ancient mysteries could preserve context, but they could also preserve nonsense. Modern classified systems can protect genuine security, but they can also protect failure. Professional licensing can protect patients, but it can also protect incumbents. Academic peer review can filter bad work, but it can also filter novelty. There is no institution so wise that its gate should be treated as sacred.

This is where the contrarian position differs from aristocratic nostalgia. The aim is not to restore a permanent initiated class that rules the uninitiated. The aim is to admit that some boundaries are necessary while making the path through them depend on relevant capability rather than inherited identity. A society can be radically unequal in expertise without being a caste society.

The same standard should govern cultural autonomy. A community asking outsiders to leave it alone has a strong claim when adults can leave, internal dissent is possible, and the practices at stake do not impose severe irreversible harm on people who cannot consent. Its claim weakens when autonomy means that a local authority monopolizes exit, violence, information, or the future of children. "Culture" cannot be a magic word that converts domination into authenticity.

And the same standard governs humanitarian intervention. If an aid program cannot say what recipient refusal would make it withdraw, it is not a gift. If a development project can survive only by continually disciplining the people it was designed to help, it may be building dependency rather than capacity. If a

public-health measure has no condition under which emergency power ends, the emergency has become a constitution.

The hardest political discipline is not choosing the good. It is renouncing the power to pursue the good past the point where the other person ceases to be a participant and becomes material.

There is no algorithm that removes judgment. There is only a burden that should sit on the side trying to override another will. The helper should have to explain the harm, the externality, the incapacity, or the catastrophic risk that converts persuasion into authority. "We can improve the outcome" is not enough.

This book has defended gates, selective help, cultural distance, bodily refusal, and the right not to be optimized. Every one of those ideas can be abused. So can openness, universalism, public health, education, welfare, and human rights. The fact of possible abuse does not tell us which side is correct. It tells us to stop using moral vocabulary as a substitute for analysis.

The universe is not safe. Human beings are not uniformly wise. Some people will misuse freedom. Some communities will preserve bad traditions. Some gatekeepers will become corrupt. Some interventions will save lives. Some refusals will kill the person who refuses. There is no institutional design that abolishes tragedy.

The dream of compulsory benevolence is attractive because it promises to convert tragedy into administration. Enough data, expertise, education, incentives, surveillance, personalization, and care, and the human animal can finally be protected from its own error.

That dream should frighten us more than it does.

If you cannot name the evidence that would make you stop helping, you are not helping. You are ruling.

The burden of the savior is the burden of explaining why refusal may be overridden and what would make the intervention stop. This is a more demanding standard than proving benevolent intent. Intent is cheap. Most coercive systems in history contained people who believed they were preventing disorder, ignorance, sin, disease, poverty, or social collapse. The important questions concern evidence, jurisdiction, reversibility, error, and stopping conditions.

A helping institution should be able to identify the mechanism by which the intervention benefits the person or protects others. It should be able to state the uncertainty in that mechanism. It should be able to distinguish the cost of refusal

to the chooser from the cost imposed on third parties. It should ask whether a less invasive intervention preserves more agency. These are not polite administrative rituals; they are ways of preventing the moral category "good" from becoming a blank cheque.

The stopping condition is the deepest test. If every refusal triggers more counseling, every protest triggers more communication, every noncompliance triggers a stronger incentive, and every failed intervention justifies more surveillance, the system has no concept of an adult other. It has only an optimization target. A person may be allowed to say no grammatically while the institution treats the no as diagnostic information about how to obtain a later yes.

The same burden applies to secrecy and selective access. A gatekeeper must be able to say what risk is being contained and why the barrier tracks that risk. "The public would misunderstand" is too easy because it turns disagreement into evidence of incapacity. "This operational capability can cause a specific class of harm and access requires demonstrated competence" is a claim that can be examined. The book's argument is not a defense of opaque elites; it is a demand that both disclosure and restriction be justified by consequences rather than slogans.

There is no final institutional design that makes these conflicts safe. The universe is not safe, human judgment is not uniform, and every distribution of authority creates failure modes. Some people will misuse freedom. Some gatekeepers will exclude unfairly. Some communities will protect internal tyrants. Some universal rules will destroy valuable local orders. Some refusals will end in preventable death. The dream that administration can abolish these tragedies is itself one of the most dangerous forms of forced good.

The mature question is therefore not how to make benevolence harmless. It is how to keep benevolence conscious of the fact that it is power. A civilization that cannot name the evidence that would make it stop helping has crossed a line: it no longer offers a good. It governs a life.

EPILOGUE — REFUSAL IS NOT A BUG

The modern world is built around an extraordinary and admirable refusal to accept suffering as fate. Children need not die because children always died. Disease need not be sacred. Ignorance need not be inherited. Poverty need not be romanticized. Violence inside the family need not be private. Tradition is not acquitted merely because it is old.

Keep all of that. Then add the part modernity finds harder: not every imperfection is a jurisdiction.

The universe is dangerous. Biology is indifferent. Human beings are status-seeking, imitative, tribal, curious, violent, cooperative, loving, vain, inventive, frightened, and capable of reasoning themselves into almost anything. No political order will make them safe without also making them less free. No educational system will remove stupidity. No welfare state will remove bad choices. No public-health system will abolish mortality. No AI will optimize humanity without choosing what counts as optimal.

The temptation of every successful civilization is to mistake capability for authority. We can predict the risk, therefore we may prohibit it. We can improve the child, therefore we may define the adult. We can personalize the message, therefore we may continue until resistance disappears. We can detect the unhealthy preference, therefore we may redesign the environment in which preferences form. We can deliver a biological intervention, therefore trust should be automatic. We can help, therefore refusal is irrational. No.

Sometimes refusal is irrational. It is still refusal.

A competent person is not an optimization target owned by the institution with the best model. A community is not raw material for the civilization with the highest GDP. A mind is not public infrastructure merely because misinformation can spread. A body is not collective property merely because bodies affect one another. Knowledge is not harmless merely because censorship is dangerous. Equality does not require pretending that everyone is equally prepared for every responsibility. Difference does not require ranking human worth.

The position that emerges is neither comfortable liberal universalism nor hereditary elitism. It is harsher than both. Protect a floor against violence, catastrophic externality, severe incapacity, and the destruction of future agency. Above that floor, tolerate more variance than modern institutions enjoy tolerating.

Let people refuse. Let communities preserve forms outsiders dislike. Let advanced knowledge have real prerequisites. Let help become deeper where there is actual uptake. Let some bad choices remain bad choices rather than policy failures.

AI will make this discipline harder because it will make intervention cheaper. It will become easier to explain, monitor, predict, nudge, tailor, diagnose, and persuade. The bureaucrat of the future may not command. He may offer an assistant that knows exactly how to make command unnecessary.

That is why the right not to be saved is not nostalgia. It is a future right.

Civilization should be able to make a case for itself and survive hearing no. Science should be strong enough to distinguish evidence from obedience. Humanism should be confident enough to protect people who do not want to become culturally identical to its professional class. AI should be powerful enough to help and restrained enough not to treat every refusal as an optimization failure.

There are worse outcomes than being left behind.

One of them is being carried somewhere you never agreed to go.

The temptation to rescue is one of civilization's noblest instincts. It is also one of the easiest instincts to weaponize because the rescuer can experience resistance as confirmation of his moral role. If the other person refuses, the refusal becomes evidence that he does not understand. If he understands and still refuses, the refusal becomes evidence that he is irrational, manipulated, culturally trapped, psychologically unwell, or socially irresponsible. At the end of that sequence, no possible answer from the recipient can terminate the mandate to help.

A civilization confident in its achievements should be able to tolerate a more dangerous possibility: the other person may understand the offer and still prefer another life. That preference may be mistaken. It may preserve a bad tradition. It may lead to poverty, illness, lost opportunity, or regret. Freedom is not the prediction that autonomous people will converge on enlightened outcomes. It is the decision that some domains remain theirs even when convergence would make administration easier.

The same is true of knowledge. Universal access to basic learning is one of modernity's great achievements, but executable capability is not morally identical to abstract information. Some gates can be justified when consequences are large and competence matters. The gate should track the capability, not inherited identity. It should be possible to cross through learning. It should remain open to

criticism. Those requirements do not make gatekeeping harmless; they make it answerable.

Cultures deserve a related restraint. A society can protect people from clear domination without treating every difference as unfinished modernization. It can support exit without forcing assimilation. It can allow voluntary distance without restoring caste. None of this guarantees harmony. It trades the fantasy of final convergence for the messier possibility of coexistence among groups that remain genuinely different.

Artificial intelligence makes these old questions urgent because it can lower the cost of intervention toward zero. Every refusal can trigger another explanation. Every hesitation can be modeled. Every person can receive a different argument. Every gate can become personalized, and every program of social improvement can become adaptive. The danger is not only an authoritarian AI. It is an obedient AI serving an institution whose objective has no stopping rule.

The right not to be saved is therefore not a romantic defense of ignorance, disease, poverty, or isolation. It is a limit on jurisdiction. It says that evidence of benefit is necessary for many interventions but not sufficient for ownership of another person's life. It says that competence can matter without becoming human rank, that culture can matter without becoming biological destiny, and that refusal can be tragic without becoming invalid.

The universe gives us no promise that freedom will end well. Biology is indifferent, history is violent, and societies make catastrophic mistakes. The alternative promise — that sufficiently intelligent institutions can eliminate tragedy by managing human choice — is more comforting and, for that reason, more dangerous. A world in which nobody is allowed to fall can become a world in which nobody is allowed to walk without supervision.

There are worse outcomes than being left behind. One of them is being carried somewhere you never agreed to go.

SELECTED BIBLIOGRAPHY

The bibliography below prioritizes sources directly used to build the historical, psychological, public-health, institutional, and AI arguments in the book. It is deliberately selective rather than encyclopedic.

- Ajana, Btihaj. 2013. *Governing through Biometrics: The Biopolitics of Identity*. Palgrave Macmillan. <https://doi.org/10.1057/9781137290755>.
- Angrist, Joshua D., and Alan B. Krueger. 1991. "Does Compulsory School Attendance Affect Schooling and Earnings?" *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 106 (4): 979–1014. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2937954>.
- Bai, Hui, Jan G. Voelkel, Sean Muldowney, et al. 2025. "LLM-Generated Messages Can Persuade Humans on Policy Issues." *Nature Communications* 16: 6037. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-025-61345-5>.
- Baird, Sarah, Francisco H. G. Ferreira, Berk Özler, and Michael Woolcock. 2013. "Relative Effectiveness of Conditional and Unconditional Cash Transfers for Schooling Outcomes in Developing Countries: A Systematic Review." *Campbell Systematic Reviews* 9. <https://doi.org/10.4073/csr.2013.8>.
- Bardosh, Kevin, Alex de Figueiredo, Rachel Gur-Arie, et al. 2022. "The Unintended Consequences of COVID-19 Vaccine Policy: Why Mandates, Passports and Restrictions May Cause More Harm Than Good." *BMJ Global Health* 7 (5): e008684. <https://doi.org/10.1136/bmjgh-2022-008684>.
- Berlin, Isaiah. 1969 [1958]. "Two Concepts of Liberty." In *Four Essays on Liberty*. Oxford University Press.
- Betsch, Cornelia, and Robert Böhm. 2016. "Detrimental Effects of Introducing Partial Compulsory Vaccination: Experimental Evidence." *European Journal of Public Health* 26 (3): 378–381. <https://doi.org/10.1093/eurpub/ckv154>.
- Bostrom, Nick. 2011. "Information Hazards: A Typology of Potential Harms from Knowledge." *Review of Contemporary Philosophy* 10: 44–79.
- Bowden, Hugh. 2010. *Mystery Cults of the Ancient World*. Princeton University Press.
- Brehm, Jack W. 1966. *A Theory of Psychological Reactance*. Academic Press.
- Bremmer, Jan N. 2014. *Initiation into the Mysteries of the Ancient World*. De Gruyter. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9783110299557>.
- Burkert, Walter. 1987. *Ancient Mystery Cults*. Harvard University Press.
- Camerer, Colin, George Loewenstein, and Martin Weber. 1989. "The Curse of Knowledge in Economic Settings: An Experimental Analysis." *Journal of Political Economy* 97 (5): 1232–1254. <https://doi.org/10.1086/261651>.
- Chi, Michelene T. H., Paul J. Feltovich, and Robert Glaser. 1981. "Categorization and Representation of Physics Problems by Experts and Novices." *Cognitive Science* 5 (2): 121–152. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15516709cog0502_2.

- Conly, Sarah. 2013. *Against Autonomy: Justifying Coercive Paternalism*. Cambridge University Press.
- Cosmopoulos, Michael B. 2015. *Bronze Age Eleusis and the Origins of the Eleusinian Mysteries*. Cambridge University Press.
- Council of Europe. 1997. *Convention for the Protection of Human Rights and Dignity of the Human Being with Regard to the Application of Biology and Medicine (Oviedo Convention)*, Article 5.
- Crowder, George. 2007. "Two Concepts of Liberal Pluralism." *Political Theory* 35 (2): 121–146.
- Dworkin, Gerald. 1972. "Paternalism." *The Monist* 56 (1): 64–84. <https://doi.org/10.5840/monist197256119>.
- Eubanks, Virginia. 2018. *Automating Inequality: How High-Tech Tools Profile, Police, and Punish the Poor*. St. Martin's Press.
- Feir, Donna L. 2016. "The Long-Term Effects of Forcible Assimilation Policy: The Case of Indian Boarding Schools." *Canadian Journal of Economics* 49 (2): 433–480.
- Fine, Paul, Ken Eames, and David L. Heymann. 2011. "'Herd Immunity': A Rough Guide." *Clinical Infectious Diseases* 52 (7): 911–916. <https://doi.org/10.1093/cid/cir007>.
- Gillmore, Julian D., Ed Gane, Julian Taubel, et al. 2021. "CRISPR-Cas9 In Vivo Gene Editing for Transthyretin Amyloidosis." *New England Journal of Medicine* 385 (6): 493–502. <https://doi.org/10.1056/NEJMoa2107454>.
- Gintis, Herbert. 2011. "Gene–Culture Coevolution and the Nature of Human Sociality." *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B* 366: 878–888. <https://doi.org/10.1098/rstb.2010.0310>.
- Hardwig, John. 1985. "Epistemic Dependence." *Journal of Philosophy* 82 (7): 335–349.
- Haushofer, Johannes, and Jeremy Shapiro. 2016. "The Short-Term Impact of Unconditional Cash Transfers to the Poor: Experimental Evidence from Kenya." *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 131 (4): 1973–2042. <https://doi.org/10.1093/qje/qjw025>.
- Hayek, F. A. 1945. "The Use of Knowledge in Society." *American Economic Review* 35 (4): 519–530.
- Henrich, Joseph, Steven J. Heine, and Ara Norenzayan. 2010. "The Weirdest People in the World?" *Behavioral and Brain Sciences* 33 (2–3): 61–83. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0140525X0999152X>.
- Hopgood, Stephen. 2013. *The Endtimes of Human Rights*. Cornell University Press.
- Hou, Xucheng, Tal Zaks, Robert Langer, and Yizhou Dong. 2021. "Lipid Nanoparticles for mRNA Delivery." *Nature Reviews Materials* 6: 1078–1094. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41578-021-00358-0>.
- Jones, Maggie E. C. 2024. "The Intergenerational Legacy of Indian Residential Schools." *Demography* 61 (6): 1871–1895. <https://doi.org/10.1215/00703370-11679677>.
- Kalyuga, Slava, Paul Ayres, Paul Chandler, and John Sweller. 2003. "The Expertise Reversal Effect." *Educational Psychologist* 38 (1): 23–31. https://doi.org/10.1207/S15326985EP3801_4.

- Kegan, Robert. 1994. In *Over Our Heads: The Mental Demands of Modern Life*. Harvard University Press.
- Kestin, Greg, Kelly Miller, Anna Klates, Tim Milbourne, and Greg Ponti. 2025. "AI Tutoring Outperforms In-Class Active Learning: An RCT Introducing a Novel Research-Based Design in an Authentic Educational Setting." *Scientific Reports* 15: 17458. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-025-97652-6>.
- Kisely, Steve R., Leslie A. Campbell, and Neil O'Reilly. 2017. "Compulsory Community and Involuntary Outpatient Treatment for People with Severe Mental Disorders." *Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews* 3: CD004408. <https://doi.org/10.1002/14651858.CD004408.pub5>.
- Kruger, Justin, and David Dunning. 1999. "Unskilled and Unaware of It." *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 77 (6): 1121–1134. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.77.6.1121>.
- Kunda, Ziva. 1990. "The Case for Motivated Reasoning." *Psychological Bulletin* 108 (3): 480–498. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.108.3.480>.
- Laland, Kevin N., John Odling-Smee, and Sean Myles. 2010. "How Culture Shaped the Human Genome." *Nature Reviews Genetics* 11: 137–148.
- Lee, Caitlin, and Joan L. Robinson. 2016. "Systematic Review of the Effect of Immunization Mandates on Uptake of Routine Childhood Immunizations." *Journal of Infection* 72 (6): 659–666.
- Lleras-Muney, Adriana. 2005. "The Relationship Between Education and Adult Mortality in the United States." *Review of Economic Studies* 72 (1): 189–221.
- Loevinger, Jane. 1979. "Construct Validity of the Sentence Completion Test of Ego Development." *Applied Psychological Measurement* 3 (3): 281–311. <https://doi.org/10.1177/014662167900300301>.
- Manners, John, and Kevin Durkin. 2001. "A Critical Review of the Validity of Ego Development Theory and Its Measurement." *Journal of Personality Assessment* 77 (3): 541–567. https://doi.org/10.1207/S15327752JPA7703_12.
- Martin, Alicia R., Masahiro Kanai, Yoichiro Kamatani, Yukinori Okada, Benjamin M. Neale, and Mark J. Daly. 2019. "Clinical Use of Current Polygenic Risk Scores May Exacerbate Health Disparities." *Nature Genetics* 51: 584–591. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41588-019-0379-x>.
- Matz, Sandra C., Jake D. Teeny, Sumer S. Vaid, Gabriella M. Harari, and Moran Cerf. 2024. "The Potential of Generative AI for Personalized Persuasion at Scale." *Scientific Reports* 14: 4692. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-024-53755-0>.
- Mello, Michelle M., Ross D. Silverman, and Saad B. Omer. 2020. "Ensuring Uptake of Vaccines against SARS-CoV-2." *New England Journal of Medicine* 383 (14): 1296–1299. <https://doi.org/10.1056/NEJMp2020926>.
- Mill, John Stuart. 1859. *On Liberty*.
- Moyn, Samuel. 2018. *Not Enough: Human Rights in an Unequal World*. Belknap Press of Harvard University Press.

- Musunuru, Kiran, Sarah A. Grandinette, Xiao Wang, et al. 2025. "Patient-Specific In Vivo Gene Editing to Treat a Rare Genetic Disease." *New England Journal of Medicine* 392 (22): 2235–2243. <https://doi.org/10.1056/NEJMoa2504747>.
- Oliu-Barton, Miquel, Bary S. R. Pradelski, Philippe Aghion, et al. 2022. "The Effect of COVID Certificates on Vaccine Uptake, Health Outcomes, and the Economy." *Nature Communications* 13: 3942. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-022-31394-1>.
- Oreopoulos, Philip. 2006. "Estimating Average and Local Average Treatment Effects of Education When Compulsory Schooling Laws Really Matter." *American Economic Review* 96 (1): 152–175.
- Ostrom, Elinor. 2010. "Beyond Markets and States: Polycentric Governance of Complex Economic Systems." *American Economic Review* 100 (3): 641–672.
- Pattaro, Serena, Nick Bailey, Evan Williams, Marcia Gibson, Victoria Wells, Mark Tranmer, and Chris Dibben. 2022. "The Impacts of Benefit Sanctions: A Scoping Review of the Quantitative Research Evidence." *Journal of Social Policy* 51 (3): 611–653.
- Resnik, David B. 2006. "Openness versus Secrecy in Scientific Research." *Episteme* 2 (3): 135–147.
- Richerson, Peter J., Robert Boyd, and Joseph Henrich. 2010. "Gene–Culture Coevolution in the Age of Genomics." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 107 (Suppl. 2): 8985–8992.
- Roberts, Dorothy. 1997. *Killing the Black Body: Race, Reproduction, and the Meaning of Liberty*. Pantheon Books.
- Rosenberg, Noah A., Jonathan K. Pritchard, James L. Weber, et al. 2002. "Genetic Structure of Human Populations." *Science* 298 (5602): 2381–2385. <https://doi.org/10.1126/science.1078311>.
- Roser, Max, Esteban Ortiz-Ospina, and Hannah Ritchie. 2025. "Life Expectancy." *Our World in Data*. Accessed August 29, 2026.
- Salvi, Francesco, Manoel Horta Ribeiro, Riccardo Gallotti, and Robert West. 2025. "On the Conversational Persuasiveness of GPT-4." *Nature Human Behaviour* 9: 1645–1653. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-025-02194-6>.
- Scott, James C. 1998. *Seeing Like a State: How Certain Schemes to Improve the Human Condition Have Failed*. Yale University Press.
- Simmel, Georg. 1906. "The Sociology of Secrecy and of Secret Societies." *American Journal of Sociology* 11 (4): 441–498.
- Sosis, Richard, and Eric R. Bressler. 2003. "Cooperation and Commune Longevity: A Test of the Costly Signaling Theory of Religion." *Cross-Cultural Research* 37 (2): 211–239.
- Steindl, Christina, Eva Jonas, Sandra Sittenthaler, Eva Traut-Mattausch, and Jeff Greenberg. 2015. "Understanding Psychological Reactance: New Developments and Findings." *Zeitschrift für Psychologie* 223 (4): 205–214. <https://doi.org/10.1027/2151-2604/a000222>.
- Stephens, Melvin, Jr., and Dou-Yan Yang. 2014. "Compulsory Education and the Benefits of Schooling." *American Economic Review* 104 (6): 1777–1792. <https://doi.org/10.1257/aer.104.6.1777>.

- Sweller, John, Jeroen J. G. van Merriënboer, and Fred Paas. 2019. "Cognitive Architecture and Instructional Design: 20 Years Later." *Educational Psychology Review* 31: 261–292.
- Thaler, Richard H., and Cass R. Sunstein. 2003. "Libertarian Paternalism." *American Economic Review* 93 (2): 175–179. <https://doi.org/10.1257/000282803321947001>.
- U.S. Food and Drug Administration. 2024. Platform Technology Designation Program for Drug Development: Draft Guidance for Industry. May 2024.
- UNESCO. 2005. Universal Declaration on Bioethics and Human Rights, Article 6.
- Ustinova, Yulia. 2009. *Caves and the Ancient Greek Mind: Descending Underground in the Search for Ultimate Truth*. Oxford University Press.
- Werb, Dan, Adeeba Kamarulzaman, Meaghan C. Meacham, et al. 2016. "The Effectiveness of Compulsory Drug Treatment: A Systematic Review." *International Journal of Drug Policy* 28: 1–9.
- Whitehouse, Harvey. 2021. *The Ritual Animal: Imitation and Cohesion in the Evolution of Social Complexity*. Oxford University Press.
- World Health Organization. 2022a. Global Guidance Framework for the Responsible Use of the Life Sciences: Mitigating Biorisks and Governing Dual-Use Research.
- World Health Organization. 2022b. COVID-19 and Mandatory Vaccination: Ethical Considerations. Policy Brief, 30 May 2022.
- Xygalatas, Dimitris, Panagiotis Mitkidis, Ronald Fischer, et al. 2013. "Extreme Rituals Promote Prosociality." *Psychological Science* 24 (8): 1602–1605. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0956797612472910>.